How to Master Your Money God's Way

10 Biblical Lessons for Lasting Financial Peace

Andrew C. Zoll

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Dear Christian Brother or Sister,

My name is Andrew Zoll, and I'm a Financial Advisor at Ryleigh Wealth Management.

I'm honored that you've downloaded this book, and my prayer is that it equips and encourages you in your journey of biblical stewardship. Let me share a little about myself and why I created this resource.

I've been a financial advisor for five years, specializing in retirement planning, legacy planning, and tax-efficient strategies – all through a lens of honoring God with wealth. My passion is working with Christian families who desire to steward their resources in a way that leaves a Kingdom impact.

As a former pastor, I understand the deep desire to align every financial decision with biblical principles. I also know the weight of life's financial challenges, like balancing work, family, and faith. It's a joy to walk alongside believers like you, providing clarity and a clear path toward achieving your God-honoring goals.

For those who value credentials, I hold Series 7 and 66 licenses and am a Chartered Retirement Planning Counselor®. My investment philosophy centers on biblical stewardship, emphasizing long-term quality, passive investing, and faith-driven principles.

I'd love to hear your story and how I can support you. Please reach out by calling me at (719) 627-5373, connecting on LinkedIn, emailing me at andrew@ryleighwm.com, or setting an appointment using this link:

https://calendly.com/andrew-zoll/clarity-call

Thank you for taking the time to engage with this material. I'm grateful for the opportunity to serve you and your family.

Andrew C. Zoll, CRPC®

1

God Owns Everything

"The earth is the LORD's and the fullness thereof..."
Psalm 24:1

What would change if you truly believed that everything you own belongs to God? It's a simple question, but the implications are profound. Most of us view money, possessions, and even our time as things we've earned through our own hard work and talent.

But Scripture paints a very different picture: *everything* – our homes, our bank accounts, our cars, the air we breathe, and even our *lives* – belongs to God. We are not owners. We are stewards. And our task is to manage God's resources wisely.

The Lie of Ownership in a "Hustle Culture" World

In our culture that celebrates self-sufficiency, pulling yourself up by your bootstraps, and hustling and grinding until you make your dreams a reality, it's easy to fall into the trap of thinking that what we have is

ours alone. This disconnect can lead to poor decisions, anxiety, and confusion about God's design for our wealth.

Whether you're feeling overwhelmed by financial burdens or simply seeking to align your decisions more closely with God's will, a deep understanding of the principle of stewardship is foundational for honoring God with your life and your money.

Myth: "If I acknowledge God's ownership of my wealth, I can't enjoy it and I'll have to give most of it away."

Truth: Stewardship isn't about loss, it's about freedom. When God owns your wealth, He assumes responsibility for your needs (Philippians 4:19) and often invites you to enjoy it more freely (Deuteronomy 14:26, Nehemiah 8:9-12).

Understanding the Context of Psalm 24

"*The earth is the LORD's and the fullness thereof, the world and those who dwell therein,*" declares Psalm 24:1. This is a bold declaration of God's sovereignty. Written by David, this verse situates God as the Creator and rightful owner of all things. The language leaves no ambiguity: "the fullness thereof," includes the natural world, human achievements, and material wealth. From the tallest mountain to the smallest atom, it all belongs to God. But what does that mean for us practically?

David likely wrote this Psalm as a part of a celebratory procession, possibly when the Ark of the Covenant was being brought to Jerusalem. This verse reflects a high reverence for God's power and majesty. By acknowledging God as the ultimate owner, David reminds us that humanity's role is not to hoard or claim ownership, but to steward what God has entrusted to us.

This perspective is reiterated throughout Scripture. From Deuteronomy 10:14 to Colossians 1:16, the Word of God repeatedly affirms God's total ownership. Even the air we breathe is His loan to us. God's ownership is comprehensive and unquestionable. He is not only the Creator, but also the Sustainer of all things.

From Burnout to Peace: Jerry and Katie's Story*

I've seen firsthand how acknowledging God as the owner of everything can transform not just your finances, but your entire approach to life. Let me show you how this is true in the lives of some of my clients.

Scripture Spotlight

Psalm 24:1 declares, "The earth is the LORD's and the fullness thereof." This isn't just a verse to memorize—it's the foundation for how Christians should approach all of life, especially finances. When we grasp this truth, every financial decision becomes an opportunity to honor God with what already belongs to Him.

When I first met my clients, Jerry and Katie, they were steeped in hustle-culture, working 80-hour weeks, Jerry to keep his business running, and Katie in her own-high pressure sales job. They were so busy "building their empire" that they hired a live-in nanny to raise their kids. Psalm 24:1 shattered their illusion of ownership.

They acknowledged that while they thought they were building security and stability, they were really selling precious moments that no amount of money could ever buy back. Together, we rebuilt their budget around wisdom, generosity, and rest. We prioritized a savings-first approach to their spending, freeing them up to begin giving generously and created a "legacy fund" for their kids– with only one income.

Today, Katie is where she wants to be: at home, schooling and raising her own kids and they finally feel peace with God, knowing that they've aligned their finances with His purposes.

Jerry and Katie's story isn't uncommon. When we forget God's ownership, we risk more than financial instability, we risk our most precious relationships and our peace. Their journey shows that stewardship isn't about earning less, it's about aligning more with God's design.

What Happens When We Forget the Owner

When we cling to a "my money, my rules" philosophy, we invite anxiety, debt, and fractured relationships. I've watched friends and family sabotage marriages over hidden spending, reject generosity out of fear, and burn out chasing "success" all because they forgot the Owner. According to EEW Magazine, financial struggles were one of the leading causes of divorce among Christian couples, second only to infidelity. And all of this can be avoided by simply remembering who owns it all and living in agreement with His directives.

This isn't just theory. Financial strife rooted in "ownership" thinking has devastating consequences.

Why Many Advisors Miss the Mark for Christians

Many financial advisors are skilled at growing wealth, but Christian investors need more than spreadsheets and stock picks. They need a

counselor who understands the eternal significance of every dollar. Here's where most secular strategies fall short:

1. They Prioritize Returns Over Reverence

Most advisors focus solely on maximizing profits, often overlooking the values and ethics behind investments. A Christian may ask, "Does this investment align with God's priorities?" But many advisors can't or won't navigate these concerns. For example, they may recommend funds that support industries conflicting with biblical values, simply because they deliver higher returns.

2. They Ignore Spiritual Stewardship

Few financial advisors integrate practices like tithing, debt freedom, or legacy giving into their plans. Yet Proverbs 3:9 calls us to honor God with our wealth. These spiritual priorities must shape financial plans, but many advisors are unequipped to guide Christians through these decisions.

3. They Can't Navigate Faith-Based Tradeoffs

Should you tithe during a layoff? What's the biblical response to debt in a market downturn? Should you give generously when your savings are small? Secular advisors often miss the deeper questions of trust, obedience, and stewardship that Christians face. Without a faith lens, these moments of tension are left unanswered.

Why You Don't Have to Navigate Stewardship Alone

Stewardship is simple in theory but complicated in practice. How do you budget when medical bills pile up? Give generously during a layoff? Leave a legacy that honors Christ?

In Exodus 18, when Moses tried to lead Israel alone, he burned out. His father-in-law Jethro urged him to delegate, saying, "You and the people with you will certainly wear yourselves out, for the thing is too heavy for you. You are not able to do it alone." (v. 18). Moses heeded this counsel, appointing leaders to share the burden.

Biblical Pattern

Even the most godly leaders needed financial counsel: Moses needed Jethro's organizational wisdom (Exodus 18), David needed Nathan's accountability (2 Samuel 12), and Rehoboam's kingdom divided when he rejected the counsel of experienced advisors (1 Kings 12). No believer—regardless of spiritual maturity—should navigate financial stewardship alone.

Later, in 1 Kings 12, when Rehoboam became king, he rejected the elders' wise counsel to lighten Israel's tax burden and instead followed his peers' advice to "make their yoke heavier." The result? A divided kingdom. This story warns us: ignore wise counselors at your peril.

This is where godly counsel matters. Just as Moses needed Jethro's guidance, and Rehoboam divided the kingdom of Israel by failing to heed sound advice, we need counselors who help us align our finances with God's Word. In my work, I've walked with clients through layoffs, market downturns, medical crises, and legacy plans, not with worldly strategies or short-term fixes, but by aligning their finances with God's Word.

As a CRPC® and former pastor, I bridge faith and finance uniquely. While secular advisors focus on returns, I ask: “How can your money glorify God?” This approach has helped clients donate tens of thousands of dollars to ministries, leave inheritance for grandkids, and retire with purpose.

In Chapter 10, you’ll learn how to find a financial advisor who doesn’t just manage your portfolio, but champions your faith. (Spoiler alert: It starts with asking the right questions.) For now, remember: You don’t have to navigate stewardship alone.

Practical Steps to Stewardship

These aren’t just theories. They’re strategies I’ve used to help clients save thousands, eliminate debt, and fund legacies. For example, Step 2 (spending audit) helped several of my clients redirect an average of $500/month* toward their God-given priorities.

1. Pray a stewardship prayer over your money and possessions.

A stewardship prayer can help shift your mindset from scarcity to trust: “*Lord, these resources are Yours. Show me how to use them for Your glory. Amen.*”

2. Do a spending audit.

A spending audit reveals hidden priorities. *“For where your treasure is, there your heart will be also,”* Matthew 6:21. Review your spending for last month. What percentage honored God? Adjust your spending accordingly.

3. Perform an ownership check.

Before making purchases, ask, "Does this align with the Owner's priorities?" An ownership check guards against impulsive spending. As 1 Corinthians 10:31 says, *"So, whether you eat or drink, or whatever you do,* ***do all to the glory of God."***

Questions for Reflection

- What areas of your finances have you treated as "yours" instead of God's?
- How might acknowledging God as the owner of everything ease your financial stress?

If these questions feel overwhelming, you're not alone. On clarity calls, I help clients untangle these struggles daily. Many people tell me that after these calls, they finally stop feeling guilty about money and see it as a tool for worship.

If you're struggling to surrender control, I invite you to schedule a free clarity call on stewardship with me here to get counsel on your next steps.

Closing Prayer

"Father, I confess my grip on 'my' money. Quiet my fears and teach me to steward Your gifts with joy. Amen."

2

Live Within Your Means

"The borrower is the slave of the lender."
Proverbs 22:7

What would be different for you if you woke up and had no payments to make to someone else? No credit cards. No car payment. No mortgage. No student loans. Nothing. This is only possible by living within your means.

Living within your means isn't just about budgeting, it's about freedom. The Bible is clear that debt can be a form of bondage, as Proverbs 22:7 warns: "*The borrower is slave of the lender.*" Yet, in a culture where credit is king and "buy now, pay later" is normalized, living within your means feels like a countercultural act of rebellion.

The truth is, many Christians don't associate financial freedom with spiritual obedience, but Scripture repeatedly ties the two together. Living within your means is a tangible way to honor God, avoid the stress of debt, and create space for generosity and Kingdom impact. In

Myth: If I can afford the monthly payment, I can afford the purchase.

Fact: Affording payments is not the same as affording ownership. Debt keeps you paying for the past, while wise stewardship allows you to invest in the future.

this chapter, we'll explore why this principle is so vital, what Scripture says about it, and how you can start living it out today.

The Lie of "Easy Payments"

While your grandparents' culture knew that debt was bad, its siren call is everywhere today. It's inescapable. When you buy something online, the screen flashes offering to break your purchases down into monthly payments, whether it's a computer, appliance, household goods, or toys– you can even finance your groceries (what a world, right?!). All of this leads to a culture that's drowning in debt, accumulated largely because of living beyond its means.

According to a December 2024 survey from the Motley Fool, the average American household has about $8,871 in credit card debt and CNBC states nearly 50% of Americans are living paycheck to paycheck (up from less than 40% in 2022). These factors don't just affect our bank accounts either – they spill over into our relationships. The Jiminez Law Firm says that between 20% and 40% of all divorces are because of money.

Christians intuitively know that the assertion of Proverbs 22:7 is true. The borrower is indeed the slave of the lender. And if you're in Christ, you were called to freedom. Galatians 5:1 commands us: "*For freedom*

Christ has set us free; stand firm therefore, and do not submit again to a yoke of slavery."

When you submit yourself to the yoke of slavery found in debt, you cannot live in the freedom to which Christ calls you. And it leads to anxiety, sleepless nights, and fear that you'll never escape. It causes conflict between spouses and beloved family members. And worse, you're robbed of the gift of generosity. You cannot invest in eternal priorities. Those "easy payments" are more like "easy shackles". By embracing God's principles for financial stewardship, you can break free from this cycle and experience true peace and purpose in your finances.

Biblical Wisdom on Debt and Spending

"*The borrower is the slave of the lender.*" If you've ever been in serious debt, you can feel these words in your soul. Having debt that you can't pay off limits your choices. Until you pay it off, debt keeps you stuck. You must earn, not so that you can build wealth for yourself or for the Lord, but for someone else. If you keep going into debt, it's time to glorify God with your finances and take control.

What should you do if you find yourself trapped in debt? Scripture may as well give a one-word response: "RUN!!!" Proverbs 6:1–5 says:

My son, if you have put up security for your neighbor,
have given your pledge for a stranger,
if you are snared in the words of your mouth,
caught in the words of your mouth,

then do this, my son, and save yourself,
for you have come into the hand of your neighbor:
go, hasten, and plead urgently with your neighbor.
Give your eyes no sleep
and your eyelids no slumber;
save yourself like a gazelle from the hand of the hunter,
like a bird from the hand of the fowler.

In plain language, this passage describes someone who has gone into debt. One who has "put up security" or has "given a pledge" has put up collateral for a loan just like you might with a car or a house for a loan today. The difference is that in Proverbs, the one being described has pledged his life as collateral.

Did you know?

The word, "mortgage" comes from a combination of the French words *mort* ("dead") and *gage* ("pledge"). It is literally a pledge until you die.

What's the prescription? Behave like a gazelle caught in the hand of a hunter or a bird caught in the hand of the fowler. The biblical prescription is to fight for your life because you *are* fighting for your life. Work like crazy. Take on extra hours. Start a side-hustle. Do anything you can to free yourself from this slavery, because while it hangs over your head, you remain trapped. Stuck. Unable to fulfill your God-given purpose. As Gandalf says on the walls of Minas Tirith, "FIGHT!!!"

Myth: I'll start saving once I make more money.

Fact: If you don't save when you have little, you won't save when you have more. Proverbs 21:20 teaches that the wise store up resources, but fools spend all they have. Financial wisdom starts now, not later.

When you live within your means, you are able to build wealth and make a kingdom impact. In short, you are wise. Proverbs 21:20 says, "*Precious treasure*

and oil are in a wise man's dwelling, but a foolish man devours it." Storing up treasure and oil is impossible if you spend more than you make. I know it sounds obvious, but you'd be surprised how many people don't make that simple connection.

From Slavery to Freedom: Kerry's Story*

My client, "Kerry," is the owner of a very successful insurance agency. And while she was making good money, she was living beyond her means. It wasn't intentional and it happened gradually. She had a few great years and convinced herself that she deserved to spend a little extra. "Treat yourself!" became the mantra she repeated to herself. Splurging became the norm and before she knew it, lifestyle creep had trapped her.

All it took was one bad quarter for her to realize how bad her situation had gotten. She found herself struggling to make payments on the very things she once thought were rewards. The stress of mounting debt began to weigh on her, and for the first time, she questioned the financial choices that had led her there.

One day, Kerry came across Proverbs 22:7: "*The borrower is slave to the lender.*" That was the stark reality check she needed. Kerry realized that despite her success, she wasn't free. Her lenders owned her lifestyle. Convicted and determined, she sought help to restructure her finances and commit to a debt-free life.

Together, we took stock of her real income, got her on a budget that didn't make her feel like a pauper. We then created a structured debt-

payoff plan that broke the chains of her debt one at a time within 18 months. Instead of spending first and maybe sometimes saving whatever was left, I helped Kerry open an account that deposits her income to savings first and automatically sends the money she's agreed to budget to her checking account.

Without the weight of debt, Kerry can now sleep soundly, knowing that she is not the slave of anyone. She can make financial decisions with confidence and finds joy in saving and giving generously to her church and the ministries that she cares about. Kerry walks in financial freedom, unburdened by debt and empowered to use her wealth for God's glory.

Walking in Wisdom with Others

Maybe Kerry's story is familiar to you. Many Christians struggle with the tension between financial responsibility and the pressure to maintain a certain lifestyle. But the good news is that you don't have to navigate these challenges alone.

Wise financial stewardship isn't merely about making better decisions, it's also about making them with the right guidance. Too often, Christians turn to secular financial advisors who may prioritize wealth accumulation over biblical stewardship. But true financial wisdom comes from advisors who understand that your money isn't just a tool for comfort, it's a resource entrusted to you by God to serve His purposes.

Many financial advisors can help you make more money, but faith-centric ones are equipped to help you honor God with it. If your financial plan doesn't align with God's wisdom, then no amount of wealth will bring you peace. That's why it's essential to have counsel that considers both financial principles and biblical convictions.

As a CRPC® and former pastor, I don't just look at your finances, I look at your calling. My approach helps clients like Kerry not only get out of debt but also:

- Develop a God-honoring financial plan
- Create margin for generosity and Kingdom impact
- Align investments with biblical values
- Replace anxiety with confidence and peace with God

If you're ready to move from financial stress to financial wisdom, I invite you to book a no-obligation clarity call with a guide who understands both faith and finance. You don't have to figure this out alone. Let's build a financial plan that reflects your trust in God.

Practical Steps to Live Within Your Means

Living within your means isn't just about cutting expenses, it's about creating financial margin so you can live with freedom, peace, and generosity. Here are four simple, biblically grounded steps that I've walked through with many of my clients to help you make immediate progress:

1. Track every dollar for 30 Days.

For the next 30 days, write down every dollar you spend. Use a budgeting app like EveryDollar, YNAB, QuickBooks or a simple notebook. By the end of the month, you'll see exactly where your money is going and be able to identify easy areas to cut back.

Proverbs 27:23-24 says, "*Know well the condition of your flocks, and give attention to your herds, for riches do not last forever; and does a crown endure to all generations?*" Tracking every dollar will help you to know the condition of your "flocks".

2. Practice a 24-hour spending rule.

Before making any non-essential purchase over $100 (or another amount that fits your budget), wait 24 hours before buying it. This simple pause will help you avoid impulsive and hasty purchases and redirect your money toward things that matter.

Proverbs 21:5 says, "*The plans of the diligent lead surely to abundance, but everyone who is hasty comes only to poverty.*" This intentional pause slows you down so that your haste will not lead you to poverty.

3. Save before you spend.

Set up your paychecks to go to a savings account first. Then deliberately decide how much of that you will spend and transfer that much to your checking account. If you feel like this is impossible, I invite you to a clarity call with me. I help clients with this every single day.

Again, Proverbs 21:20 says, "*Precious treasure and oil are in a wise man's dwelling, but a foolish man devours it.*" Taking a savings-first approach means that you won't devour your "treasure" and "oil," and you will have plenty in your time of need.

4. Give first to break the cycle of scarcity.
Commit to giving first, even if it's just a small amount. Before paying bills or making any purchases, set aside a percentage to give to your church or a cause you believe in. This step shifts your financial focus from fear to faith.

In Luke 6:38, Jesus says, "*give, and it will be given to you. Good measure, pressed down, shaken together, running over, will be put into your lap. For with the measure you use it will be measured back to you.*" We'll talk more about generosity in Chapter 5, but committing to giving first acknowledges God as the owner and aligns you with His priorities – something which God promises to bless.

Questions for Reflection

- How has debt impacted your ability to live with financial peace and generosity?
- What would it look like for you to act with gazelle-like intensity to break free from debt?

If these questions feel daunting, remember: you don't have to navigate them alone. Every day, I help clients take practical, biblically grounded steps toward financial peace.

Closing Prayer

"Father, I confess the times I have lived beyond my means instead of trusting in Your provision. Teach me contentment, wisdom, and discipline so I can steward Your resources faithfully. Amen."

3

Save for the Future

"Precious treasure and oil are in a wise man's dwelling, but a foolish man devours it."
Proverbs 21:20

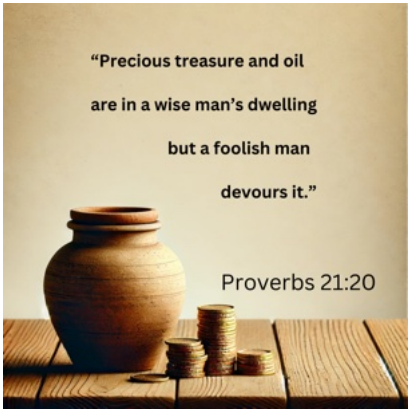
If your water heater went out and you didn't have credit cards, would you be able to pay for it? For many, the answer is no. Bankrate's 2025 Savings Report found that only 41% of Americans have enough savings to cover an unexpected $1,000 expense without going into debt, meaning nearly 60% would have to borrow money, use credit, or simply go without.

Emergencies aren't a matter of if but when. The car breaks down, the refrigerator quits, a medical bill arrives. It's only a matter of time before life throws an unexpected expense your way. However, despite knowing that emergencies happen, most people still don't prepare. Instead of saving, they assume they'll "figure it out later." But "later" always comes. And when it does, the unprepared are left with stress, debt, and difficult decisions.

If this sounds familiar, you're not alone. Our culture makes it easy to spend now and worry later, but is that really in line with what God says about wisdom and money?

The High Cost of Ignoring Your Financial Safety Net

Murphy's Law says, "Anything that can go wrong will go wrong," and when it comes to finances, this feels especially true. Just when you think you're on solid ground, the sink clogs, the pipes leak, the car needs a new radiator, often at the worst possible time (these have all happened to me in the last year).



If we know that emergencies are inevitable, why don't more people save for them? As a financial advisor *and* as a pastor, I've heard all of the excuses (and that's just what they are):

- "I don't make enough money to save."
- "I'll start saving when I have extra money."
- "If something happens, I'll just use a credit card."
- "Why let money sit in a bank when I could be investing it?"
- "I don't need to save. The Lord will provide." (More on this later.)

The excuses can feel reasonable and sometimes even downright spiritual… until reality hits. The problem is that life doesn't wait for you

to be "ready" for an emergency. In fact, I've seen over and over that the less prepared you are, they more likely you are to have a financial emergency.

Did You Know?

Most Americans can't handle a $1,000 emergency. Bankrate's 2025 savings report found that nearly 60% of Americans would have to borrow money, use credit, or simply go without if faced with an unexpected $1,000 expense.

A flat tire doesn't care that payday is next week. A kid won't decide not to play on the treadmill and break his nose (yes, this actually happened) because your budget is tight this month. Your water heater won't decide to function perfectly until you close that deal or get that bonus. And if these emergencies hit when there's nothing in savings, the results are predictable:

Debt dependence ➜ Financial Anxiety ➜ Missed Opportunities

Debt Dependence

With no emergency fund, debt becomes your safety net, trapping you in high-interest debt that lingers long after the crisis has abated. The natural result of being trapped in debt is...

Financial Anxiety

You feel like you're constantly on the brink of disaster – because you are! Every unexpected bill is a potential tragedy. You become panicky and risk-averse, creating stress, fear, and relational stress. And when you feel this way, it leads to...

Missed Opportunities

Instead of being able to say "yes" to opportunities that God sends your way, you can't because you were foolish. Missionaries visiting your church that you want to support? Nope. A new giving campaign that

you're excited about? Uh-uh. Big holiday push to buy gifts for Angel Tree kids? Not a chance. That would be like the airplane cabin depressurizing, the masks dropping down, and you trying to get someone else's mask on before yours.

The truth is, not saving is a choice. And it's a choice that often leads to hardship, regret, and financial bondage. But just as poor choices create financial stress, wise choices can build security, peace, and generosity. The Bible offers clear guidance on how to prepare for the future, and when we follow God's wisdom, financial emergencies no longer have to feel like disasters.

Myth: Saving money shows a lack of faith in God's provision.

Fact: Wise saving is biblical stewardship. There are no verses in Scripture which divorce faith and action, but plenty that rebuke inaction, like the parable of the talents in Matthew 25.

A word of caution:
In Luke 12, Jesus tells the story of a rich and successful man who was rich toward himself, but not "rich toward God." He had a successful year and had accumulated far more than he could consume. Notice his thoughts were focused on his own greatness and not the greatness of the Provider of his bounty: *"I will do this: I will tear down my barns and build larger ones, and there I will store all my grain and my goods. 19 And I will say to my soul, 'Soul, you have ample goods laid up for many years; relax, eat, drink, be merry.'"* What was God's response? *"Fool! This night your soul is required of you, and the things you have prepared, whose will they be?"*

The lesson? Saving is wise, but hoarding without a Kingdom perspective is foolish. Thankfully, Scripture doesn't leave us guessing. God's Word is full of financial wisdom, showing us how to prepare well

while keeping our focus on Him. Let's look at what the Bible teaches about saving wisely.

Biblical Wisdom on Saving

God's Word consistently praises wisdom, diligence, and preparation. Saving isn't about hoarding, it's about stewardship. The Bible warns against reckless consumption but applauds wise preparation. When done in a God-glorifying way, saving allows us to provide for our families and create margin for generosity.

Wise saving provides both security for your family and freedom to be generous when God calls you to give. The Bible is clear: the wise prepare and the foolish consume everything they have, setting nothing aside, eventually to their own ruin.

Joseph Saves Egypt through Diligent Saving

At the end of the book of Genesis God guides Joseph to become second only to Pharaoh after he was the only one that could interpret Pharaoh's troubling dream. Joseph rightly tells Pharaoh that seven years of plenty are ahead of them followed by seven years of famine. To prepare for the famine, Joseph shrewdly recommends saving 20% of all the produce of the land during the years of plenty and storing it in reserve.

"Let Pharaoh proceed to appoint overseers over the land and take one-fifth of the produce of the land of Egypt during the seven plentiful years. And let them gather all the food of these good years that are coming and store up grain under the authority of Pharaoh for food in the cities, and let them keep it. That food shall be a reserve for the land against the seven years of

famine that are to occur in the land of Egypt, so that the land may not perish through the famine," Exodus 41:34-36.

Joseph's story shows us that faith and action go hand in hand. Joseph didn't dismiss the coming years of famine with excuses like, "God will provide." He understood that abundance doesn't last forever, and his God-given wisdom led him to save during the times of plenty so that Egypt (and as a result, his family) could survive the famine. Joseph teaches us that wise preparation is an act of faith. Whether in seasons of plenty or just consistent income, saving money ensures that when challenges come, we're not caught off guard.

Learn from the Ants

In Proverbs 6, we are instructed to learn from the ants, taking lessons from them about preparation, hard work, and good stewardship.

"Go to the ant, O sluggard; consider her ways, and be wise. Without having any chief, officer, or ruler, she prepares her bread in summer and gathers her food in harvest," Proverbs 6:6-8.

The ant doesn't wait for a crisis to arise before saving. It begins acting before the need arises. In the same way, a wise person saves consistently – whether for emergencies, future needs, or to be ready for unexpected opportunities to bless others – without waiting for external pressure to force them into action.

These biblical principles are just as true today as they were when they were written thousands of years ago. Just as Joseph's preparation saved a nation and the ant's diligence ensures survival, I've seen firsthand how saving transforms lives. Let me share the story of one of my clients who went from financial instability to security by obeying this wisdom.

The Savings Buffer: John and Matt's Story*

When most people think about financial planning, they think about retirement accounts, investments, and growing their wealth, but wise planning starts with the basics: cash savings for the unexpected. "John" and "Matt," a father and son duo I've worked with for years, understand this firsthand.

Like many people, they were diligent about investing, but they lacked a cash buffer for unexpected expenses. They had a solid long-term plan, but had neglected preparing for possible short-term emergencies.

When John and Matt came to me, they were eager to strengthen their financial foundation. So we worked together to not only grow their investments but also build an emergency fund designed to give them peace of mind when they encountered the inevitable financial curveball.

That buffer was put to the test this year.

One evening, their water heater failed. It wasn't just a minor repair. It was beyond saving. After researching their options, they decided to upgrade to a tankless water heater – a better long-term solution but one that came with a $6,000 price tag.

Had they been unprepared, this decision could have been stressful and financially disruptive. They might have needed to dip into their investments at the wrong time or put the expense on a credit card, paying for it long after the work was done.

Instead, because they had prioritized saving, they were able to handle the cost with confidence, without debt, without stress, and without hesitation.

For John and Matt, this was more about financial freedom and peace of mind than the water heater itself. They didn't have to scramble or make desperate financial moves. They had prepared ahead of time, just like Joseph storing grain in Egypt and the ant gathering food in summer.

Their story illustrates why saving *both* a good idea and biblical wisdom in action.

Emergencies will happen. The only question is will you be prepared for them?

John and Matt were able to handle their emergency without stress because they prioritized saving before the need arose. John and Matt didn't only save money. They bought themselves peace of mind, flexibility, and the ability to make wise choices without financial stress. That's the power of saving with biblical wisdom.

Building a Habit of Saving

John and Matt didn't do anything extraordinary. They didn't stumble upon a secret formula or win the lottery. But they did build the habit of saving. And that made all the difference.

For most people, the hardest part of saving isn't knowing they should do it, it's actually getting started. Life gets in the way, bills pile up, and before you know it, another month has passed without setting anything aside.

Practical Tip

Use the "savings-first" approach by directing your income to a savings account first, then transferring only your budgeted spending money to checking. This simple habit reversal makes saving automatic rather than optional.

That's why saving isn't about good intentions. It's about having a system that makes it automatic and effortless.

Most people want to build a savings buffer, but they keep running into the same roadblocks:

- "I'll save whatever's left at the end of the month." (Spoiler alert: There's never anything left.)
- "I just need to make more money first." (Without a plan, every raise gets eaten up by lifestyle creep.)
- "I'll start next month." ("Next month" never comes.)

The problem? Saving rarely feels urgent, until it's too late.

If you want to break the cycle of financial stress, you don't need willpower. You need a plan that actually works for your life.

As a CRPC® and former pastor, I don't just help people invest for the future, I help them build financial stability today by creating savings strategies that align with biblical principles.

Together, we'll design a plan that makes saving consistent and automatic, creating a structured approach so you save every month, no

matter what. By saving first, you ensure that you'll always have a God-honoring buffer before any money is spent.

Like John and Matt, you don't have to live in fear of unexpected expenses. By creating a simple, automatic savings plan, you can build financial security without the stress, so that when life happens, you're ready.

If you're tired of hoping you'll save and ready to know you will, I'd be honored to help. Book a clarity call today, and let's create a savings plan that works for you.

How to Adopt a Savings-First Lifestyle

Saving money doesn't happen by accident. It happens with intentional planning. Whether you're a newbie to saving anything, or you just want to strengthen your financial foundation, here are three practical, biblical steps to help you build up a savings consistently.

1. Start with savings before spending money.

Most people save whatever is left at the end of the month. But with that approach, how often is anything left? The wise prioritize saving first. Instead of having your paycheck sent to a checking account that's linked to your debit card, send it to savings first. Then *intentionally* transfer what you've agreed to spend during the month to your checking account.

Proverbs 21:20 says, *"Precious treasure and oil are in a wise man's dwelling, but a foolish man devours it."* When you start with savings, you're acting wisely.

2. Build an emergency fund before investing more.
Before focusing on investing or paying extra toward debt, set aside money for emergencies. Without savings, you'll be one crisis away from financial disaster. Proverbs 22:3 says, *"The prudent sees danger and hides himself, but the simple go on and suffer for it."* Trouble will come. Will you be prudent and hide yourself, or will you be "simple" and ignore it?

Get a quick win. Save $1,000 for emergencies (be sure to keep this separate from your checking account!). Once you reach that, work toward saving 3-6 months' worth of living expenses. Once you've done this, what were once financial catastrophes will become opportunities to thank the Lord for His wisdom and provision.

3. Follow the 80-10-10 rule.
In Matthew 6:21, Jesus says, *"For where your treasure is, there your heart will be also."* The way we allocate our resources is a direct reflection of our hearts. A helpful rule of thumb to direct your heart to God is to allocate your income like this:

- **10% to giving,** putting God first in your finances through tithing and generosity.
- **10% to savings,** paying yourself by setting money aside for the future.
- **80% for everything else**, living within your means by budgeting wisely.

If living on 80% of what you make feels overwhelming, start with a smaller percentage and commit to working your way up every month. Progress is better than perfection. And if you want additional help, let's talk.

Saving isn't about fear or hoarding. Saving is about wise stewardship. When you save consistently and intentionally, you create margin to handle life's surprises and say "yes" to the generosity to which God calls you.

Questions for Reflection

- What small, immediate step can you take this week to start (or strengthen) your savings habit?
- How does the way you save (or don't save) reflect your trust in God's provision?

Saving reflects a trust in God's provision and wise stewardship of His resources. When we save with intention, we create margin to respond to life's challenges and opportunities with faith instead of fear.

Closing Prayer

"Father, I confess the times I have lived only for today and neglected to prepare for tomorrow. Teach me to save with wisdom, not fear, and to trust in Your provision as I steward what You've given me. Amen."

4

Avoid Greed, Pursue Contentment

"Keep your life free from love of money, and be content with what you have..."
Hebrews 13:5

What would it take for you to feel financially secure? A higher salary? A bigger house? A fully funded retirement account?

If you're like most people, your answer is probably "just a little more."

In a famous interview, a reporter once asked billionaire John D. Rockefeller, "How much money is enough?" His answer? "Just a little bit more." If one of the richest men in history didn't feel financially satisfied, what does that say about the human heart?

The world constantly tells us that more is better– more money, more possessions, more success. But Scripture warns that chasing wealth as the key to happiness is a trap. No matter how much you have, without contentment, it will never feel like enough.

So, what's the alternative? Hebrews 13:5 gives us the answer: "Keep your life free from love of money, and be content with what you have."

God calls us to a different way of living– one where joy isn't tied to our bank accounts, but to our trust in Him.

In this chapter, we'll explore why greed is so dangerous, how biblical contentment brings true freedom, and practical ways to shift from chasing wealth to finding peace in God's provision.

"More Will Make Me Happy"

Our culture bombards us with a simple, seductive message: happiness comes through acquisition. More money. A bigger house. A newer car. The latest phone. Designer clothes. Luxury vacations. The list is endless.

This belief is so deeply embedded in our thinking that we often don't even recognize it. We scroll through social media, comparing our lives to carefully curated highlight reels. We watch commercials that promise fulfillment through products. We're told that success equals a bigger paycheck and more impressive possessions.

According to the American Psychological Association's Stress in America 2022 Survey, 72% of Americans reported feeling stressed about money at least sometimes. Yet research from the Proceedings of the

National Academy of Sciences shows that, beyond covering basic needs, additional wealth brings diminishing returns in happiness.

The lie is powerful because it contains a grain of truth: money *can* solve certain problems and provide opportunities. But when we believe that "more" is the answer to our deepest needs, we set ourselves up for disappointment and spiritual danger.

Jesus warned about this in Luke 12:15: "*Take care, and be on your guard against all covetousness, for one's life does not consist in the abundance of his possessions.*" The pursuit of "more" isn't just financially unwise; it's spiritually dangerous. It places our hope in things that will ultimately fail us.

When we fall for the lie that "more will make me happy," we enter a cycle that never ends and never satisfies. The temporary high of a new purchase quickly fades, requiring another acquisition to recreate the feeling. It's like trying to fill a bucket with a hole in the bottom – no matter how much you pour in, it never fills up.

The antidote to this endless cycle isn't earning more or spending less– it's contentment. And thankfully, Scripture offers us a better way forward.

Biblical Wisdom on Contentment and Greed

The Bible doesn't mince words when it comes to the spiritual dangers of materialism and the freedom found in contentment. Let's look at what God's Word teaches us about these opposing forces.

The Warnings Against Greed

In 1 Timothy 6:9-10, Paul writes: "*But those who desire to be rich fall into temptation, into a snare, into many senseless and harmful desires that plunge people into ruin and destruction. For the love of money is a root of all kinds of evils. It is through this craving that some have wandered away from the faith and pierced themselves with many pangs.*"

Notice that the problem isn't money itself, but the *love* of money. When we orient our lives around acquiring wealth, we don't just risk financial pitfalls; we risk spiritual destruction. The desire for more can lead us away from faith and into "many pangs"—a poignant description of the anxiety, emptiness, and damaged relationships that often accompany materialism.

Did You Know?

Studies show that spending money on experiences rather than possessions generally leads to greater happiness. This aligns with Jesus's teaching that "life does not consist in the abundance of possessions" (Luke 12:15).

Jesus echoed this warning in Matthew 6:24: "*No one can serve two masters, for either he will hate the one and love the other, or he will be devoted to the one and despise the other. You cannot serve God and money.*" When we allow money and possessions to become our functional master—the thing we trust in, worry about, and orient our decisions around—we inevitably push God to the margins.

The Freedom of Contentment

In Philippians 4:11-13, Paul reveals a radical approach to possessions: "*I have learned in whatever situation I am to be content. I know how to be brought low, and I know how to abound. In any and every circumstance, I have learned the secret of facing plenty and hunger, abundance and need. I can do all things through him who strengthens me.*"

The "secret" Paul discovered wasn't a financial strategy; it was a spiritual reality—contentment comes through Christ's strength, not our circumstances. This isn't passive resignation but active trust in God's provision.

Hebrews 13:5-6 makes this connection explicit: "*Keep your life free from love of money, and be content with what you have, for he has said, 'I will never leave you nor forsake you.' So we can confidently say, 'The Lord is my helper; I will not fear; what can man do to me?*"

Biblical contentment isn't based on having enough stuff; it's based on having a God who will never leave us. It's not the absence of desire but the presence of trust.

The early church demonstrated this radical contentment in Acts 4:32-35, where believers shared their possessions freely, ensuring that "*there was not a needy person among them*." Their grip on possessions was loosened by their trust in God and love for one another.

This doesn't mean that Christians should be financially irresponsible or refuse to plan for the future. Proverbs still praises diligence and wisdom in financial matters. But it does mean that our security comes from God, not our bank accounts.

From Anxious Success to Contentment: Josh's Story*

My friend Josh seemed to have it all—a stellar career as a top-performing sales executive in logistics, recognition throughout his industry, and all the trappings of success. By worldly standards, he was the definition of achievement. He'd made President's Club 7 years in a

row at his company of 16,000+ employees and was named company MVP two years running—literally the #1 salesperson in the entire organization.

Scripture Spotlight

In Philippians 4:11-12, Paul writes that he has "learned in whatever situation... to be content." Contentment isn't natural—it's a spiritual discipline that must be cultivated through practice and God's strength.

Despite his impressive professional accomplishments and substantial income, Josh found himself feeling increasingly empty. Each new sales target reached, each bonus achieved, each award received—they all brought momentary satisfaction that quickly faded. The accolades that once thrilled him now left him questioning their ultimate significance.

Josh confided in me that he'd built his identity around his performance. He was known as the person who always exceeded targets and closed seemingly impossible deals. Eventually, he recognized he was measuring his worth by his quarterly results, creating an exhausting cycle where the target constantly moved and left him perpetually chasing the next achievement.

While Josh wasn't in financial trouble—he managed his money well—he was suffering from a different kind of poverty: a poverty of purpose. His pursuit of success had become all-consuming, leaving little room for deeper relationships or spiritual growth.

The turning point came unexpectedly. After achieving his biggest year yet, Josh found himself alone in a hotel room after a celebration, feeling strangely hollow inside. Despite being celebrated by hundreds of colleagues for his remarkable performance, he felt more isolated than ever.

That week, Josh began a journey back to his faith. As he was driving down the road with his wife, he felt the gentle prompting of the Holy Spirit telling him to return to church. He looked at his wife and said, “Babe, I want to start going to church.” Shocked, she looked back at him, and revealed that she’d just been thinking the same thing (the Holy Spirit is funny like that).

He started reading Scripture again, reconnecting with the truth that his value didn't come from his performance but from his identity in Christ. Passages like Matthew 16:26 spoke directly to his situation: "*For what will it profit a man if he gains the whole world and forfeits his soul?*”

Over the next year, Josh underwent a profound transformation. He didn't abandon his logistics career—he continued to excel at what he did. But he no longer derived his sense of worth from his achievements. He started mentoring younger colleagues, became more involved in his church, and approached his work as an opportunity to demonstrate integrity and serve others rather than just advance himself. Watching him become so passionate for the love of Christ has been an absolute joy.

Warning Sign

If you frequently find yourself saying "I'll be happy when..." (I get a raise, buy a bigger house, etc.), you may be falling into the contentment trap. True contentment comes from Christ, not circumstances (Philippians 4:13).

Josh now approaches his work from a place of peace rather than striving. He's found that he no longer needs professional success to feel complete, having discovered true contentment in Christ alone.

Josh's life now includes regular sabbath rest, generous giving, and rich community—things his previous schedule never allowed room for. His

perspective on money has shifted dramatically from viewing wealth as primarily about security and status to seeing it as a matter of stewardship and service.

Josh's story illustrates what Scripture teaches: true contentment doesn't come from achieving more, but from finding our purpose in Christ. It's not about abandoning ambition; it's about aligning our ambition with eternal values.

Finding a Guide for Your Contentment Journey

Josh's transformation didn't happen overnight, and it didn't happen alone. Like many Christians, he needed support from his wife, church community, and friends who understood both practical realities and biblical wisdom—people who could help him align his life and resources with his renewed faith.

Proverbs 15:22 reminds us: "*Without counsel plans fail, but with many advisers they succeed*." This wisdom is especially true when navigating the delicate balance between financial stewardship and spiritual contentment.

Most financial advisors are skilled at helping clients build wealth, but few are equipped to address the heart issues behind our financial decisions. They can tell you how to get more, but not when enough is enough. They can optimize your investment returns, but not help you invest in what truly matters.

As a financial advisor who is also a former pastor, I approach money differently. I believe that true financial success isn't measured by the

size of your portfolio, but by the alignment between your resources and God's purposes for your life.

With my clients, I focus on:

- **Heart-focused financial planning**: Identifying the spiritual and emotional factors driving your financial decisions.
- **Values-based budgeting**: Creating spending plans that reflect what you truly value, not what culture values.
- **Contentment practices**: Developing habits that cultivate gratitude and combat the "more is better" mentality.
- **Kingdom-minded investing**: Aligning your investments with biblical principles and eternal priorities.

In a world that constantly tells you to want more, having a guide who understands the freedom of "enough" can be transformative. If you're tired of the endless pursuit of more and ready to experience the peace of contentment, I'd be honored to help.

Schedule a no-obligation clarity call with me to explore how biblical contentment could transform your relationship with money and with God.

Cultivating Contentment

Contentment doesn't happen by accident in our acquisition-focused culture. It requires intentional practice and a renewed mind. Here are four biblical strategies to help you cultivate contentment in your daily life:

1. Practice deliberate gratitude.
1 Thessalonians 5:18 instructs us to "*give thanks in all circumstances; for this is the will of God in Christ Jesus for you*." Gratitude is one of the most powerful antidotes to greed and discontent.

Create a daily habit of thanking God for specific provisions, both material and spiritual. Keep a gratitude journal where you write down three blessings each day. When you're tempted to complain about what you lack, redirect your thoughts to what God has already provided.

Many of my clients find that this simple practice significantly reduces their impulse spending and increases their overall satisfaction with life.

2. Implement a waiting period for purchases.
Proverbs 21:5 says, "The plans of the diligent lead surely to abundance, but everyone who is hasty comes only to poverty." Hasty purchasing decisions are often driven by discontentment rather than necessity.

For non-essential purchases over $100, commit to a 1-day minimum waiting period. Use this time to pray about the purchase, evaluate whether it aligns with your values, and consider if there are better uses for those resources. Often, you'll find that the desire fades as you gain perspective.

This isn't about depriving yourself; it's about ensuring that your spending reflects your true priorities rather than momentary impulses.

3. Practice generous giving.
In Acts 20:35, Paul quotes Jesus: "*It is more blessed to give than to receive*." Generosity breaks the grip of materialism by reminding us that we are channels of God's provision, not merely consumers.

Set aside a percentage of your income specifically for spontaneous generosity—beyond your regular tithing. When you notice needs around you, you'll be prepared to respond without hesitation.

Spending money on others actually brings more lasting happiness than spending it on ourselves. Generosity isn't just spiritually beneficial; it's psychologically powerful. We'll talk more about this in the next chapter.

4. Conduct a comparison fast.
Social media and advertising fuel discontent by constantly showcasing what we don't have. Romans 12:2 urges us, "*Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewal of your mind*."

Consider a 30-day "comparison fast"—eliminating or significantly reducing social media, television commercials, and shopping websites. Replace this time with Scripture reading, particularly passages about God's provision and eternal priorities.

Many of my clients report that temporarily disconnecting from these sources of comparison dramatically increases their contentment and clarifies their financial priorities.

Remember, contentment is not a destination; it's a daily practice. As you implement these strategies, be patient with yourself and celebrate progress, knowing that God is at work in you, "*both to will and to work for his good pleasure*" (Philippians 2:13).

Questions for Reflection

- In what areas of your life do you find yourself thinking that "just a little more" would bring satisfaction?
- How might your financial decisions change if your security came from God's presence rather than your possessions?

The answers to these questions can be transformative, but they often require honest self-examination and biblical guidance. If you'd like to explore them further, I'd be honored to help through a clarity call.

Closing Prayer

“Father, forgive me for the times I’ve made my life about my possessions. I confess that in doing this, I let them own me, rather than owning them. Help me to be content, knowing that in Christ, I have everything I need. Amen."

5

Give Generously

“God loves a cheerful giver.”
2 Corinthians 9:7

What if I told you that one of the most counterintuitive financial practices—giving your money away—is actually the key to experiencing true financial freedom and joy? It sounds backward, doesn't it? In a world fixated on accumulation and security, the idea of intentionally parting with your hard-earned money seems financially irresponsible.

Yet Scripture repeatedly affirms that generosity isn't just a nice spiritual practice—it's a fundamental aspect of God's design for our finances. As 2 Corinthians 9:7 reminds us, "*God loves a cheerful giver.*" Not a reluctant giver. Not a resentful giver. Not even a dutiful giver. A cheerful giver—one who finds genuine delight in the act of giving.

But for many Christians, generosity creates anxiety rather than joy. We wonder: "Can I afford to give?" "What if I need that money later?" "Am I giving enough?" These questions reveal a tension between what we know Scripture teaches and the financial realities we face. This chapter aims to resolve that tension, showing you how to align your giving with both biblical wisdom and sound financial planning.

Whether you're struggling to start giving, feeling guilty about not giving enough, or simply wanting to be more strategic in your generosity, understanding God's perspective on giving can transform your entire relationship with money. When we grasp that generosity is less about obligation and more about opportunity, everything changes.

The Lie of "I Can't Afford to Give"

One of the most persistent lies about giving is that it's something we'll do "someday"—when we have more money, less debt, or greater financial security. The logic seems sound: take care of your own financial house first, then you'll be in a position to give to others.

This approach reflects our culture's emphasis on self-sufficiency and financial independence. We're taught to save for emergencies, invest for retirement, pay off debt, and build wealth. All good things, certainly. But where does giving fit into this picture?

For many Christians, the answer is "later." According to Barna's 2022 research article "What Is a Tithe? New Data on Perceptions of the 10 Percent," 42% of practicing Christians report tithing regularly. However, this means that more than half of practicing Christians are not engaging in this biblical financial practice, despite many acknowledging its importance. Financial constraints - whether real or

perceived - are frequently cited as the primary reason for limited giving.

But here's the problem with the "I'll give later" approach: Later rarely comes. As income increases, so do expenses and lifestyle expectations. The mortgage gets bigger, the cars get nicer, the vacations get fancier—and suddenly, despite earning more, we still feel we "can't afford" to give.

What's really happening here isn't a math problem; it's a heart problem. When we say "I can't afford to give," what we're often really saying is "I'm prioritizing my wants over others' needs." It's a mindset that places security in our own resources rather than in God's provision.

Jesus addressed this mindset directly in Luke 12:22-34. After instructing His disciples not to worry about their material needs, He concludes with this radical command: "*Sell your possessions, and give to the needy. Provide yourselves with moneybags that do not grow old, with a treasure in the heavens that does not fail, where no thief approaches and no moth destroys. For where your treasure is, there will your heart be also.*"

Jesus wasn't saying that possessions are inherently wrong, but He was challenging the assumption that financial security comes from what we keep rather than what we give. In God's upside-down economy, giving doesn't diminish our security—it enhances it by placing our trust in the right place.

The truth is, you can't afford not to give. When we withhold generosity, we miss out on the joy, freedom, and spiritual growth that comes through giving. We may gain more money in our accounts, but we lose something far more valuable—the opportunity to participate in God's work and experience His promises to those who give cheerfully.

Biblical Wisdom on Generosity

Scripture doesn't just encourage giving; it reveals giving as central to God's character and His design for our finances. Throughout the Bible, we see a consistent thread: generosity isn't optional for God's people—it's essential.

Generosity Reflects God's Nature

The Bible begins with God's generosity—creating a world of abundance and blessing for humanity to enjoy. John 3:16 reminds us that "*God so loved the world, that he gave his only Son*," revealing that sacrificial giving is at the very heart of God's character.

When we give generously, we aren't just following a rule; we're reflecting the image of our Creator. As Jesus taught in Luke 6:35-36, we are to "*be merciful, even as your Father is merciful*." Our generosity is a tangible expression of God's character working through us.

Tithing as a Starting Point

The practice of tithing—giving the first 10% of our income—appears throughout Scripture. In Genesis 14:20, Abraham gave a tenth of everything to Melchizedek. In Malachi 3:10, God challenges His people: "*Bring the full tithe into the storehouse… and thereby put me to the test… if I will not open the windows of heaven for you and pour down for you a blessing until there is no more need.*"

While the New Testament doesn't mandate tithing in the same way, Jesus affirmed the principle in Matthew 23:23, saying that tithing should be practiced alongside justice, mercy, and faithfulness. The early

Christians often went beyond tithing, sharing their possessions freely as needs arose (Acts 4:32-35).

For many Christians today, tithing serves as a meaningful starting point for generous living—a baseline, not a ceiling. It establishes the principle that our giving is proportional (based on a percentage, not a fixed amount) and prioritized (given first, not from whatever is left over).

Giving as an Act of Worship and Trust

In 2 Corinthians 8-9, Paul frames giving not as a duty but as an act of worship—a "grace" that God works in us. He emphasizes that generosity flows from recognizing Christ's sacrifice: "*For you know the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ, that though he was rich, yet for your sake he became poor, so that you by his poverty might become rich*" (2 Corinthians 8:9).

Scripture Spotlight

In 2 Corinthians 9:6-7, Paul writes, "Whoever sows sparingly will also reap sparingly, and whoever sows bountifully will also reap bountifully... for God loves a cheerful giver." God cares not just about the amount we give, but our heart attitude in giving.

Paul also addresses the fear that often hinders giving. In 2 Corinthians 9:6-11, he offers this assurance: "*Whoever sows sparingly will also reap sparingly, and whoever sows bountifully will also reap bountifully... And God is able to make all grace abound to you, so that having all sufficiency in all things at all times, you may abound in every good work.*"

This promise doesn't guarantee material wealth to generous givers (as some prosperity teachings suggest), but it does assure us that God provides sufficiently for those who give. Our generosity doesn't diminish God's provision; it activates it in new ways.

Generosity as a Spiritual Discipline

Jesus warned about the spiritual dangers of wealth accumulation. In

Matthew 6:19-21, He cautions against storing up treasures on earth and instead encourages us to store up treasures in heaven. In Luke 12:15, He warns that "*one's life does not consist in the abundance of his possessions.*"

Generosity serves as a powerful antidote to materialism and greed. When we regularly practice giving, we loosen our grip on possessions and strengthen our attachment to eternal values. Our giving becomes both an investment in God's kingdom and a protection against idolizing wealth.

From Faithfulness to Provision: My Parents' Tithing Story

Unlike many of my clients who struggle with starting their giving journey, I grew up witnessing the power of faithful tithing firsthand through my parents. I didn't grow up rich—far from it. We always had just enough, but rarely more than that.

One of the most challenging seasons for our family came after my father retired from the Air Force. What should have been a relatively smooth transition into civilian life became a serious financial trial when my dad struggled to find a job. For six long months, our family income wasn't enough to cover the basic bills. The math simply didn't work on paper.

As a child, I would sometimes overhear my parents late at night, whispering tearfully about bills that needed to be paid and their uncertainty about how it would happen. These weren't luxuries they were worried about—these were essentials like electricity, mortgage

payments, and groceries. People from our church knew about the dire financial straits we were in.

What amazed me, even as a middle schooler, was that through all of this struggle, my parents never stopped tithing. Each Sunday, before any other expense was addressed, they would faithfully give their first 10% back to God. They maintained this discipline even when it made no logical sense from a purely financial perspective.

I remember one particularly difficult week when our pantry was nearly empty. That evening, I returned home from youth group to find our entire front porch filled with groceries. Someone had anonymously left enough food to sustain our family for weeks. There was no note, no way to thank them—just an abundance of provision that arrived at precisely the right moment.

This wasn't an isolated incident. Throughout that difficult six-month period, we experienced numerous instances of unexpected provision—a check arriving in the mail from various sources and neighbors bringing meals. None of these actions solved our entire financial situation, but collectively, they carried us through until my father finally secured steady employment.

These weren't coincidences; they were divine provision arriving at just the right time, often through channels we could never have anticipated or engineered ourselves. Through each of these experiences, my parents' faith deepened, and so did mine.

The lessons I learned watching my parents give faithfully during those lean years have shaped both my personal finances and my approach as a financial advisor. I witnessed firsthand that God's economy operates

on different principles than the world's. When we commit to giving first –even when the numbers don't add up–God remains faithful.

Years later, my parents have no regrets about their lifetime of giving. Despite never having enormous incomes, they not only provided for our family but faithfully gave to the work of the Church. And somehow, their needs were always met–not always abundantly, but always sufficiently.

Kingdom Investment Fact

Unlike other investments, giving to God's kingdom offers eternal returns. Jesus promised that treasures stored in heaven cannot be affected by market crashes, inflation, or economic downturns (Matthew 6:20).

Our family's story illustrates an important truth: Tithing isn't primarily about the impact on the recipient–though that matters greatly. It's about our own hearts and our relationship with God. It's about declaring with our finances what we believe in our hearts: that God is faithful, generous, and worthy of our trust. When we align our giving with this truth, we position ourselves to experience His provision in ways that transform not just our finances, but our faith.

Creating Your Personal Generosity Plan

My family's story highlights something I've seen repeatedly in my practice: The difference between occasional givers and consistently generous Christians isn't income level–it's intentionality. The most generous people I know aren't necessarily the wealthiest; they're the ones who have made giving a non-negotiable priority in their financial

lives. My parents weren't wealthy by any measure, but they were rich in faith and commitment to putting God first in their finances.

Developing a biblical approach to giving doesn't happen by accident in our consumer-driven culture. It requires thoughtful planning and spiritual guidance. That's where having a faith-aligned financial advisor becomes particularly valuable.

Most financial advisors focus exclusively on wealth accumulation and preservation, treating charitable giving as an afterthought or tax strategy. They may even subtly discourage significant giving as "inefficient" for your financial goals.

By contrast, a faith-centered advisor recognizes that generosity isn't in conflict with sound financial planning—it's fundamental to it. We understand that your financial goals should align with your spiritual values, not compete with them.

As a CRPC® with pastoral experience, I help clients like my parents develop generosity plans that are both biblically grounded and financially sustainable. Together, we address questions like:

- How can you increase giving while still meeting other financial responsibilities?
- What giving methods (church offerings, donor-advised funds, appreciated assets) are most appropriate for your situation?
- How can you balance planned giving with spontaneous generosity?
- How can your giving create both immediate impact and lasting legacy?

I believe that generosity should bring joy, not anxiety. If you're feeling uncertain about how to align your giving with your overall financial

picture, I invite you to schedule a no-obligation clarity call. Let's explore how strategic generosity can become a cornerstone of your financial and spiritual life.

Practical Steps

Generosity, like any spiritual discipline, grows through consistent practice. Here are four biblical approaches that have helped my clients develop hearts and habits of giving:

1. Practice the principle of first-fruits giving.
In Proverbs 3:9-10, we're instructed to "*Honor the LORD with your wealth and with the firstfruits of all your produce; then your barns will be filled with plenty, and your vats will be bursting with wine*." First-fruits giving means giving to God first, not last.

Make giving your first financial priority by automating it. Set up automatic transfers or use your church's online giving platform to transfer your giving amount on the day you receive income, before other expenses. This simple step ensures that giving doesn't get squeezed out by competing priorities. For many of my clients, the discipline of giving first actually improves their overall financial management.

2. Adopt percentage-based giving with growth goals.
In 1 Corinthians 16:2, Paul advises believers to set aside a sum of money "*in keeping with your income*." This establishes the principle that giving should be proportional to what we receive.

If you're not currently giving, start with a percentage that stretches you but doesn't create hardship (perhaps 3-5% of your income). Then establish a growth plan—commit to increasing your giving percentage each year or with each pay increase. For example, if you get a 3% raise, consider increasing your giving by 1% and keeping 2% for other needs. This allows your giving to grow steadily without requiring dramatic budget changes.

3. Create a "spontaneous giving fund."

Jesus often responded to needs He encountered with immediate generosity. In Matthew 14:14-21, He didn't tell the hungry crowd to come back next week when He had budgeted for food; He met their need on the spot.

Myth: "I'll start giving generously once I'm financially secure."

Truth: Generosity isn't the result of financial abundance; it's a spiritual discipline that shapes our relationship with money at every income level. As Jesus taught, "It is more blessed to give than to receive" (Acts 20:35).

Beyond your regular giving to church and planned charities, set aside a specific amount each month for unplanned giving opportunities. When you encounter someone in need or learn about an urgent cause, you'll be prepared to respond without hesitation. Many of my clients report that their "spontaneous giving fund" leads to some of their most meaningful giving experiences.

4. Practice secret giving.

In Matthew 6:3-4, Jesus teaches, "*But when you give to the needy, do not let your left hand know what your right hand is doing, so that your giving may be in secret. And your Father who sees in secret will reward you.*"

While not all giving needs to be anonymous, practicing secret giving helps purify our motives. Occasionally give in ways that can't be recognized or acknowledged. This might mean anonymously paying for

someone's meal, leaving an unmarked envelope for someone in need, or contributing to a cause without public recognition. Secret giving guards against the pride that can taint our generosity.

Remember, these practices aren't about earning God's favor or checking boxes. They're about aligning our financial lives with God's heart for generosity. As we give consistently and intentionally, we experience the truth of Jesus' words that "*It is more blessed to give than to receive*" (Acts 20:35).

Questions for Reflection

- How has your giving reflected (or not reflected) your trust in God's provision?
- What fears or concerns currently limit your generosity?
- If money were no object, what cause or ministry would you give to abundantly? How might God be calling you to support that work even now?

These questions aren't meant to induce guilt but to invite honest reflection. Generosity is a journey, and God meets us wherever we are on that path. If you'd like guidance in developing your giving strategy, I'm here to help through a clarity call.

Closing Prayer

“Father, forgive me for the times I've clung to what You've entrusted to me. Open my hands and my heart to give joyfully, knowing that everything I have comes from You. Help me to be generous, not out of obligation, but out of the joy of reflecting on Your generous character toward me. Amen.”

6

Be Diligent and Hardworking

“Whatever you do, work heartily, as for the Lord and not for men...”
Colossians 3:23

What would it look like if you approached your work not merely as a way to earn money, but as an act of worship? This shift in perspective can transform not only your financial life but your entire relationship with work.

In a culture that often celebrates the "get rich quick" mentality and the "four-hour workweek" dream, diligence and hard work seem like outdated virtues. We're bombarded with advertisements promising passive income, overnight success, and financial freedom with minimal effort. Social media showcases "influencers" apparently making millions while lounging on exotic beaches, creating the impression that real success means escaping work rather than embracing it.

Yet Scripture presents a radically different vision of work. From Genesis, where God himself works to create the world and assigns Adam meaningful work in the garden, to the New Testament teachings

on serving Christ through our labor, the Bible consistently affirms that diligent work is not a curse to escape but a blessing to embrace. When we work "heartily, as for the Lord," we participate in God's ongoing creativity and provision in the world.

In this chapter, we'll explore how diligence transforms not just your paycheck but your entire financial life, what Scripture says about the spiritual significance of work, and how to cultivate a God-honoring work ethic that leads to true prosperity.

The Temptation of "Easy Money"

Our culture is obsessed with the idea of making money without effort. You can hardly scroll through social media without seeing ads promising to teach you how to "make six figures while you sleep" or "quit your job and live off passive income." The implication is clear: hard work is for suckers. The truly successful have figured out how to get rich without really trying.

Warning Sign

If you're constantly attracted to "get-rich-quick" opportunities, it may indicate an underlying desire to avoid the disciplined work God has called you to. As Proverbs 13:11 teaches, "Wealth gained hastily will dwindle."

This mindset isn't new. Proverbs described similar attitudes thousands of years ago: "The sluggard buries his hand in the dish and will not even bring it back to his mouth" (Proverbs 19:24). What's changed is how sophisticated and pervasive these messages have become.

According to the Federal Trade Commission, Americans lost over $2.6 billion to investment scams in 2022 alone, many promising unrealistic returns with minimal effort. Even legitimate "side hustles" are often

marketed with unrealistic expectations about the work required for success.

The "easy money" lie is dangerous for three key reasons:

1. It Creates Unrealistic Expectations
When we believe success should come quickly and easily, normal career setbacks become catastrophic disappointments. Instead of persevering through challenges, we're tempted to jump from opportunity to opportunity, never developing the expertise and relationships that lead to true success.

2. It Devalues the Dignity of Work
God designed work as a way for humans to participate in His ongoing creation and provision. When we view work merely as a necessary evil to escape from, we miss the profound meaning and satisfaction that comes from doing good work well, regardless of the financial reward.

3. It Encourages Risky Financial Behavior
The pursuit of easy money often leads to poor financial decisions–investing in get-rich-quick schemes, accumulating debt to fund business ventures without proper planning, or neglecting steady saving in favor of hoping for a windfall. According to the FBI Cryptocurrency Fraud Report, investment scams were the most financially damaging form of fraud in 2023.

The biblical alternative isn't glamorous, but it's reliable: diligent work, steady saving, patient investing, and contentment with God's timing. As Proverbs 13:11 reminds us, "*Wealth gained hastily will dwindle, but whoever gathers little by little will increase it*." There are no true shortcuts to lasting financial well-being.

Biblical Wisdom on Diligence and Work

Scripture offers abundant guidance on the value of diligence and the spiritual significance of our work. Far from being merely a means to earn money, our work is portrayed as a central aspect of our calling as image-bearers of God.

Work as Worship

In Colossians 3:23-24, Paul writes: "*Whatever you do, work heartily, as for the Lord and not for men, knowing that from the Lord you will receive the inheritance as your reward. You are serving the Lord Christ.*" This revolutionary perspective transforms even mundane tasks into acts of worship. Whether you're preaching a sermon, performing surgery, coding software, changing diapers, or cleaning toilets, when done "as for the Lord," your work becomes a spiritual offering.

This doesn't mean every job is equally fulfilling or that we shouldn't seek to use our specific gifts. But it does mean that any honest work can be done in a way that honors God. As Martin Luther King Jr. famously said, "If a man is called to be a street sweeper, he should sweep streets even as Michelangelo painted, or Beethoven composed music, or Shakespeare wrote poetry."

The Consequences of Diligence and Laziness

Proverbs contrasts the diligent person with the sluggard (lazy person) repeatedly, showing the natural consequences of each approach:

"*The hand of the diligent will rule, while the slothful will be put to forced labor*" (Proverbs 12:24).

"*The soul of the sluggard craves and gets nothing, while the soul of the diligent is richly supplied*" (Proverbs 13:4).

"*Whoever is slothful will not roast his game, but the diligent man will get precious wealth*" (Proverbs 12:27).

Helpful Habit

Begin each workday with a brief prayer dedicating your efforts to God. This simple practice transforms ordinary tasks into sacred service.

These passages aren't promising that hard work automatically leads to wealth –many factors, including opportunity and circumstance, influence financial outcomes. But they do establish a pattern: diligence generally leads to provision and opportunity, while laziness leads to scarcity and dependence.

The Broader Purpose of Work

In Ephesians 4:28, Paul provides a striking perspective on work's purpose: "Let the thief no longer steal, but rather let him labor, doing honest work with his own hands, so that he may have something to share with anyone in need." According to this passage, we work not merely to provide for ourselves but to have the means to be generous to others.

This broader vision elevates work from mere self-preservation to participation in God's economy of generosity. Our diligence creates ripples that extend far beyond our own bank accounts, allowing us to be channels of God's provision to others.

From "Secular Job" to Sacred Calling: Jonathan's Fencing Company*

The transformation in how Christians view work isn't just an individual journey—it's beginning to reshape entire church communities. I've witnessed this firsthand in our small church, where a remarkable shift in the theology of work has occurred over the past few years, becoming ingrained in our very culture.

For years, many in our congregation held an unconscious division between their "spiritual life" and their "work life." They saw their jobs primarily as a means to provide for their families and perhaps fund ministry, but not as ministry itself. Work was the "secular" part of life—necessary but not particularly sacred.

Work-Rest Balance

God established a rhythm of six days of work followed by one of rest. Neither perpetual leisure nor workaholism reflects His design for human flourishing.

What makes our story particularly powerful is that this transformation has been led by our own pastor, Jonathan. Unlike the stereotype of pastors who may have little experience outside church walls, Jonathan exemplifies the integration of faith and work in a tangible way. After circumstances led to difficulty in the church's ability to

provide a full-time salary, Jonathan found himself at a crossroads. With a family to support, he needed to supplement his income.

Throughout his teaching, Jonathan extolled the glories of viewing work as worship and doing and excellent job to the glory of God, showing how God is portrayed as a worker from the very beginning of Scripture, and how Jesus himself was a carpenter for most of his adult life. With experience in construction and woodworking, Jonathan saw an opportunity not just to supplement his income, but to serve his community with excellence and integrity, launching a fencing company to build excellent fences to the glory of God.

A common refrain throughout the launch was Proverbs 22:29: "*Do you see a man skillful in his work? He will stand before kings; he will not stand before obscure men*." This verse provided a biblical foundation for valuing skill and excellence in ordinary work. Our pastor was modeling his own teaching in real time.

With this integrated perspective, Jonathan launched his fencing company—not as a distraction from ministry, but as an extension of it. He approached each project with meticulous attention to detail. He set fair prices, honored his time estimates, guaranteed his work far beyond industry standards, and paid his workers a more-than-fair wage for their labor (often preferring to take a loss on a job to ensure his workers made money).

The results were remarkable both spiritually and financially. In his first year, Jonathan's company generated over $100,000 in revenue—no small feat in our rural community. By the second year, that figure had grown to more than $250,000. He was able to hire three men from the

church who had been struggling with unemployment, mentoring them not just in craftsmanship but in seeing their labor as worship.

But the impact went far beyond Jonathan's business. His example inspired our entire church to reconsider our own work. This shift didn't happen overnight, and it didn't happen without theological wrestling. Many in our congregation had absorbed cultural messages from both secular society ("success means escaping hard work") and sometimes even from broader church culture ("real ministry happens in church buildings, not workplaces”).

Jonathan's dual role as both pastor and business owner has been powerful in breaking down these false dichotomies. His journey shows that when we embrace a biblical understanding of work—seeing it as a way to reflect God's character, serve others, and steward our gifts—the artificial divide between sacred and secular dissolves. His fencing company doesn't just provide income; it serves as a living sermon on the dignity of work and a platform for living out faith through diligence, excellence, and integrity.

The transformation in our church illustrates a powerful truth: Work isn't a necessary evil or merely a means to fund "real ministry." When done with excellence and the right heart, our daily work itself becomes an act of worship and a powerful witness to a watching world.

Finding Your Path to Diligent Financial Stewardship

Jonathan's story demonstrates the power of integrating faith and work, but such a transformation rarely happens in isolation. Even as our

pastor, Jonathan benefited from the wisdom of mentors, books, and fellow believers who helped him develop this integrated approach to work and ministry. Like many Christians, he needed guidance to align his vocational life with biblical principles in a culture that constantly pulls in the opposite direction.

Proverbs 15:22 reminds us: "*Without counsel plans fail, but with many advisers they succeed*." This wisdom is particularly relevant when it comes to integrating faith, work, and finances. Unfortunately, most career counselors and financial advisors address only the practical aspects of work and money, missing the spiritual dimensions that are central for Christians.

As a CRPC® who approaches finances from a biblical perspective, I help clients like Michael develop an integrated approach to work and money management that honors God and creates true prosperity. Together, we address questions like:

- How can your specific skills and talents be directed toward work that provides both income and meaning?
- What financial habits support a sustainable work life that avoids both laziness and burnout?
- How can your career decisions align with God's unique calling for your life?
- What steps can you take to develop mastery in your field while maintaining biblical priorities?

I believe that diligence in your work and diligence in your financial management are deeply connected spiritual disciplines. If you're struggling to connect your faith with your work life, or if scattered

financial decisions have left you frustrated, I'd welcome the opportunity to help you develop a more integrated approach.

Schedule a no-obligation clarity call with me to explore how biblical principles of diligence can transform both your career and your finances.

Cultivating Biblical Diligence in Today's World

Diligence isn't just about working hard; it's about working with purpose, consistency, and excellence. Here are four practical, biblically-grounded steps to cultivate this quality in your life:

1. Reframe your work as service to God.
In Romans 12:1, Paul urges us to "present your bodies as a living sacrifice, holy and acceptable to God, which is your spiritual worship." This applies to our work as much as any other area of life.

Start each workday with a brief prayer dedicating your efforts to God. Set a reminder on your phone for midday to pause and remember who you're ultimately working for. This simple practice helps maintain perspective when tasks become tedious or challenging.

Several of my clients report that this shift in mindset—from working primarily for a paycheck to working for the Lord—has not only improved their job satisfaction but also led to better performance and opportunities for advancement.

2. Practice the "10-Minute Rule" to overcome procrastination.
Proverbs 6:6-8 directs us to: "*Go to the ant, O sluggard; consider her ways, and be wise. Without having any chief, officer, or ruler, she prepares her bread in summer and gathers her food in harvest*." The ant doesn't wait for motivation; it simply gets to work.

When facing a task you're tempted to put off, commit to just 10 minutes of focused effort. Often, the hardest part is simply starting. After 10 minutes, you can reassess, but you'll frequently find that momentum carries you forward.

This approach acknowledges our human weakness while creating a path to overcome it—an application of Paul's teaching in Romans 7-8 about the struggle between our flesh and spirit.

3. Develop a "continuous improvement" mindset.
In 2 Peter 1:5-8, we're instructed to "make every effort to supplement your faith with virtue, and virtue with knowledge... For if these qualities are yours and are increasing, they keep you from being ineffective or unfruitful." This passage describes the Christian life as one of ongoing growth.

Set aside time monthly to evaluate your skills and identify one specific area for improvement. Invest in that area through books, courses, mentoring, or deliberate practice. This approach keeps you from stagnation and positions you for greater impact and opportunity.

Many successful clients maintain a personal development budget—a small but consistent investment in their own growth that yields significant returns over time.

4. Build rhythms of work and rest.
In Exodus 20:8-11, God establishes the pattern of six days of work followed by a day of rest. This rhythm reflects God's own nature and design for human flourishing.

Resist the extreme of laziness, but also the opposite extreme of workaholism. Schedule regular times of complete rest from work—not just to recharge but as an act of trust that God, not your constant labor, is your ultimate provider.

For many of my clients, creating clear boundaries between work and rest has actually improved their productivity during work hours while protecting their health and relationships. This balanced approach honors God's design while acknowledging the dignity of both work and rest.

Remember, diligence isn't about grinding yourself down with constant activity. It's about faithful, consistent effort aligned with God's purposes —approaching each task, whether seemingly significant or mundane, as an opportunity to honor Him with excellence.

Questions for Reflection

- In what ways have you been influenced by the "easy money" messages in our culture?
- How might your daily work change if you consistently viewed it as service to Christ rather than merely to an employer or customers?
- What area of your work could benefit from more diligent development or consistent effort?

These questions aren't meant to induce guilt but to invite honest reflection on how biblical diligence might transform your relationship with work and finances. If you'd like guidance in applying these principles to your specific situation, consider scheduling a clarity call with me.

Closing Prayer

"Father, forgive me for the times that I've approached the work You've given me to do as drudgery or an extension of my own glory rather than Yours. Thank you for the gift of meaningful work. Help me to work diligently for your glory. Amen."

7

Plan Your Legacy

“A good man leaves an inheritance to his children’s children…”
Proverbs 13:22

What legacy will your money leave when you're gone? It's a question many Christians avoid, either because it feels uncomfortable to contemplate our mortality or because we assume legacy planning is only for the wealthy. Yet Scripture calls us to consider not just how we use our resources today, but how they will impact generations to come.

When King David prepared for the building of the temple—a project he knew would outlive him—he didn't just gather materials. He also prepared his son Solomon with the wisdom, relationships, and vision needed to carry the work forward. In 1 Chronicles 22:5, we read that David made "*abundant preparations before his death*." This forward-thinking approach to legacy wasn't just practical; it was deeply spiritual.

Legacy planning isn't about ego or controlling the future. At its heart, it's about stewardship that extends beyond our lifetime. It's recognizing that the resources God has entrusted to us—whether modest or substantial—can continue to reflect His character and priorities even

after we're gone. In this chapter, we'll explore why legacy planning matters spiritually, what Scripture teaches about intergenerational stewardship, and how you can begin creating a legacy that honors God for generations to come.

"Legacy Planning Is Only for the Wealthy"

When most people hear "legacy planning," they imagine wealthy families with complex estate plans, trust funds, and family foundations. The implicit message is clear: if you're not leaving millions behind, you don't need to worry about your legacy.

This misconception keeps many Christians from engaging in thoughtful planning about how their resources—whatever the amount—will impact future generations. According to a 2025 Caring.com survey, only 24% of Americans have a will or other estate planning documents. According to Trust & Will, this percentage drops even lower among those with modest incomes, suggesting that many believe legacy planning isn't relevant to their situation.

But consider this: Every believer leaves a legacy, whether planned or unplanned. Without intentional planning, your legacy may not align with the values you hold dear. Your life savings could be consumed by unnecessary taxes or legal fees. Family heirlooms with significant

spiritual meaning could be sold or discarded. Most importantly, the opportunity to continue supporting ministries and causes you care about could be lost.

The truth is that legacy planning matters for everyone—not because of the size of your estate, but because of who you are in Christ. Your legacy isn't measured by financial value but by faithful stewardship of whatever God has entrusted to you.

Jesus Himself highlighted this principle in the Parable of the Talents (Matthew 25:14-30), where servants were judged not by how much they had, but by how faithfully they managed what was entrusted to them. Legacy planning is simply extending that faithful stewardship beyond your lifetime.

Biblical Wisdom on Legacy Planning

Scripture provides clear and direct teaching about legacy planning, with particular emphasis on the tangible, material inheritance believers should provide for future generations. From Genesis to Revelation, we see God's people intentionally passing on both material resources and spiritual values, with material provision serving as the foundation.

Material Provision as Minimum Standard

In Proverbs 13:22, Solomon doesn't merely suggest or recommend legacy planning; he makes a moral declaration: "*A good man leaves an inheritance to his children's children.*" Note the specific language. It is the "good man" who ensures material provision extends to grandchildren. By implication, failing to plan for a material inheritance may fall short of biblical expectations for righteousness.

This isn't presented as optional or dependent on wealth level. The principle establishes that providing materially for future generations is part of godly character. We see this exemplified in Genesis 25:5-6, where "*Abraham gave all he had to Isaac*," while also providing gifts to his other children. Material inheritance isn't an afterthought in Scripture but a concrete expression of love and care for future generations.

Intergenerational Blessing: Both Material and Spiritual
Throughout the Old Testament, the patriarchs consistently passed down both material wealth and spiritual truth. In Genesis 48:15-16, Jacob (Israel) blessed his grandsons spiritually: "*The God before whom my fathers Abraham and Isaac walked, the God who has been my shepherd all my life long to this day, the angel who has redeemed me from all evil, bless the boys*." Yet in the same chapter, he also allocated portions of the promised land—tangible property—to these same grandsons.

The pattern is clear: biblical legacy is never merely spiritual words without material provision. The spiritual blessing complements but never replaces the material inheritance.

Wisdom in Estate Distribution
The Bible doesn't suggest that all estates should be distributed equally or in the same manner. In 1 Chronicles 28:1-8, David made Solomon king and entrusted him with specific resources and responsibilities that his other children didn't receive. This wasn't favoritism but recognition of Solomon's role in carrying forward a particular aspect of the family's calling.

Similarly, Jesus' parable of the talents in Matthew 25:14-30 shows different amounts entrusted to different servants "*each according to his*

ability." The master's expectation wasn't equality of outcomes but faithful stewardship appropriate to each person's capacity.

This biblical principle gives us freedom to consider the unique needs, capabilities, and callings of our heirs when planning our estates, rather than assuming a one-size-fits-all approach.

Spiritual Legacy Alongside Material Provision

While material provision is the foundation, Scripture also emphasizes passing on faith and values. In Deuteronomy 6:4-9, Moses commands Israel to diligently teach God's commands to their children, to talk about them throughout the day, and even to write them on their doorposts.

Psalm 78:5-7 expands this view: "*He established a testimony in Jacob and appointed a law in Israel, which he commanded our fathers to teach to their children, that the next generation might know them, the children yet unborn, and arise and tell them to their children, so that they should set their hope in God and not forget the works of God, but keep his commandments.*"

The biblical model is both/and, not either/or. Material provision without spiritual guidance can lead to entitled heirs who squander their inheritance. Spiritual guidance without material provision fails to meet the biblical standard that "a good man leaves an inheritance." Together, they form a complete legacy that honors God and truly serves future generations.

From Financial Turnaround to Intergenerational Wealth: Darren's Legacy Story*

When I first met my client Darren, he was in his mid-forties and struggling with financial discipline. Despite a good income as a mortgage broker, years of impulsive spending and minimal saving had left him with significant debt and little progress toward long-term goals. His financial habits reflected a short-term mindset—living for today with little thought for tomorrow, much less future generations.

Practical Tip

Create a "legacy letter" to accompany your legal documents. This personal message explains your financial values, lessons learned, and the reasoning behind your estate decisions, transforming your legacy from mere assets to meaningful impact.

Everything changed when Darren's father passed away and left him a seven-figure inheritance. What struck Darren most wasn't just the amount, but the careful thought his father had put into the estate plan. His father had left specific instructions for certain portions, designated charitable gifts to ministries he had supported for decades, and included a heartfelt letter explaining the values behind his financial decisions.

Darren said that reading that letter was like hearing his dad's voice one last time. He wrote about how his own father had left him nothing but debt, and how he had made a covenant with God to break that cycle. That inheritance became a turning point in Darren's financial life—not because of the money itself, but because of the legacy of intentionality it represented. For the first time, Darren saw firsthand how one generation's faithfulness could bless the next, and he was determined to continue that legacy rather than squander it.

Together, we created a comprehensive financial turnaround plan. First, we used a portion of the inheritance to eliminate Darren's high-interest debt, creating immediate financial freedom. Next, we established a detailed zero-based budget to ensure he wouldn't slip back into his old spending patterns. This was crucial. An inheritance can quickly disappear without the discipline of a structured spending plan. Within three months of implementing this budget, Darren's cash flow improved dramatically, and he reported feeling in control of his money for the first time.

With debt eliminated and proper budgeting in place, we then established a proper emergency fund and structured investment accounts for retirement and college savings for his three children. But most significantly, we developed a legacy plan that would extend beyond his lifetime.

Darren explained that he wants to do for his kids and grandkids what his father did for him and more. Not just with money, but with his faith and values, creating opportunities for generations he'll never meet.

With this vision in mind, we implemented a multi-generational strategy:

1. We established a revocable living trust that would efficiently transfer assets while communicating Darren's values.
2. We created education funds for his children and future grandchildren.
3. We incorporated strategic charitable giving that reflected his faith priorities.
4. We developed a "legacy vault" containing important family documents, stories, and wisdom to be passed down.

Now, several years later, Darren's financial transformation is remarkable. He's completely debt-free, consistently saves and invests, and has become one of the most generous people I know. Most importantly, he's actively teaching his children the financial principles he learned too late, breaking negative money patterns that could have continued for generations.

Darren's story illustrates the profound impact of intergenerational wealth and wisdom. His father's thoughtful planning didn't just transfer assets—it transformed his son's entire relationship with money and launched a legacy that will likely impact generations yet unborn. Through one man's commitment to biblical stewardship, a family's financial trajectory was forever changed.

The Spiritual Discipline of Legacy Planning

Legacy planning is a spiritual discipline that few Christians have been taught to practice. Just as we need guidance in prayer, Bible study, or giving, many believers benefit from wise counsel in this important area of stewardship.

Ecclesiastes 7:12 tells us that "*the protection of wisdom is like the protection of money, and the advantage of knowledge is that wisdom preserves the life of him who has it*." When it comes to legacy planning, both financial knowledge and spiritual wisdom are essential.

Legacy Beyond Money

Material inheritance without spiritual wisdom often leads to squandered resources. Proverbs 20:21 warns, "An inheritance gained hastily in the beginning will not be blessed in the end." True legacy planning passes on both resources and values.

Many financial advisors can help with the technical aspects of estate planning (i.e. tax strategies, legal documents, and investment vehicles), but few can help you align these tools with biblical values and spiritual priorities. The result is often estate plans that efficiently transfer assets but fail to transfer the faith and values that made those assets meaningful.

As a CRPC® with pastoral experience, I help Christians like Darren develop legacy plans that reflect both sound financial principles and biblical priorities. Together, we address questions such as:

- How can your estate plan reflect your specific calling and values?
- What tools and strategies will maximize your legacy impact while minimizing taxes and complications?
- How can you prepare your heirs not just to receive assets but to steward them wisely?
- What non-financial legacy (wisdom, values, faith) do you want to intentionally pass down?

I believe your legacy deserves more than a standardized approach. Your unique story, values, and resources call for a personalized legacy plan that reflects your journey of faith and stewardship.

If you're ready to move from uncertainty to intentionality in your legacy planning, I invite you to schedule a no-obligation clarity call. Together, we can explore how your resources can continue to honor God for generations to come.

Practical Steps

Legacy planning may seem overwhelming, but it doesn't need to be. Here are four biblical approaches to get started on your legacy journey:

1. Document your current situation.

In Isaiah 38:1, God instructs King Hezekiah: "*Set your house in order, for you shall die.*" While blunt, this command reminds us of our responsibility to create order in our affairs.

Begin by gathering key information: a list of all assets and liabilities, account numbers, insurance policies, digital accounts, and important contacts. Store this information securely but make sure at least one trusted person knows how to access it if needed. This simple step prevents unnecessary confusion and stress for your loved ones.

Several of my clients keep this information in a "legacy binder" that they review annually, ensuring everything stays current and accessible.

2. Create essential legal documents.

In 2 Kings 20:1-11, Hezekiah's life was extended, but the principle remains. We are responsible for preparing for the transition of our stewardship. At minimum, every adult Christian should have:

- A will or trust that directs the distribution of your assets.
- Powers of attorney for financial and healthcare decisions.
- Advance healthcare directives that reflect your values.

Without these documents, state laws, not your wishes, will determine what happens to your resources and healthcare decisions. For parents with minor children, a will is particularly crucial as it names guardians for your children.

Even if you already have these documents, review them every 3-5 years or after major life changes to ensure they still reflect your wishes and current laws.

3. Align your beneficiary designations with your plan.
In Genesis 48, Jacob carefully blessed each of his descendants with intentionality and purpose. Similarly, your beneficiary designations on retirement accounts, life insurance policies, and other assets should align with your overall legacy plan.

Many people don't realize that these designations override instructions in your will. Take time to review all beneficiary designations to ensure they reflect your current wishes and work harmoniously with your other legacy documents.

One client discovered that her retirement account still listed her ex-husband as beneficiary, despite being divorced for over a decade. A simple 15-minute update redirected a significant asset to support her church's evangelistic work, as she intended.

4. Create a legacy letter.
Deuteronomy 6:6-7 instructs: "*These words that I command you today shall be on your heart. You shall teach them diligently to your children, and shall talk of them when you sit in your house, and when you walk by the way, and when you lie down, and when you rise.*"

Beyond legal documents, consider writing a legacy letter to your loved ones. Unlike a legal will, this personal document shares your faith journey, values, life lessons, and hopes for future generations. It can also explain the reasoning behind your estate decisions, potentially preventing misunderstandings or hurt feelings.

This letter becomes a priceless gift to your heirs, connecting them both to your assets and to your heart and faith. I've had clients read portions of their legacy letters to family members while still alive, creating meaningful conversations about values and priorities across generations.

Remember, legacy planning isn't a one-time event but an ongoing process. Start with these steps, then continue refining your plan as life circumstances change. The goal isn't perfection but faithful stewardship that extends beyond your lifetime.

Warning Sign

If you've never written down your wishes for your estate or shared your values regarding money with your children, you may be neglecting a critical aspect of biblical stewardship that could lead to family conflict and missed opportunities for Kingdom impact.

Questions for Reflection

•What values and principles would you most want to see continued through your legacy?

•How might your current approach to estate planning help or hinder your spiritual legacy?

•Beyond financial assets, what wisdom, stories, or faith lessons do you want to intentionally pass to future generations?

These questions aren't meant to create guilt but to inspire thoughtful consideration of your legacy impact. For many Christians, legacy planning becomes a meaningful spiritual exercise that clarifies priorities and strengthens family bonds.

Closing Prayer

"Father, I acknowledge that everything I have comes from You and ultimately returns to You. Give me wisdom to thoughtfully plan how to pass on the resources You've entrusted to me. Help me create a legacy that honors You, blesses others, and extends Your Kingdom work beyond my lifetime. May my children and grandchildren be blessed not just by what I leave behind, but by the faith and values I pass down. Amen."

8

Be Prepared for the Unexpected

"The prudent sees danger and hides himself, but the simple go on and suffer for it."
Proverbs 27:12

What would happen to your family financially if you couldn't work for six months? Or if you suddenly passed away? Most people prefer not to think about these scenarios. They're uncomfortable, even painful to consider. Yet the reality is that unexpected events—job loss, disability, critical illness, premature death—happen every day to people who never saw them coming.

In our optimistic culture, we often operate under the "it won't happen to me" assumption. We focus on growth, opportunity, and positive outcomes, which is generally healthy. But this mindset can leave us dangerously exposed when life takes an unexpected turn. According to a 2023 study by the Federal Reserve, 37% of Americans would struggle to cover an unexpected $400 expense without borrowing money or selling possessions. Even more concerning, Bankrate reports that 43% of Americans are have no life insurance (and that number gets larger the younger they are with Gen Z being a whopping 64%), leaving

millions of families vulnerable to financial ruin after the loss of a provider. Perhaps even more devastating, according to Guardian Life's 12th Annual Workplace Benefits Study, 49% of Americans have no disability coverage either.

Scripture doesn't promise believers immunity from life's hardships. What it does offer is wisdom to help us navigate them with faith and foresight. Proverbs 27:12 presents a stark contrast between two approaches to potential danger: "*The prudent sees danger and hides himself, but the simple go on and suffer for it.*" This isn't about living in fear; it's about living with wisdom.

In this chapter, we'll explore how biblical prudence applies to protecting your family from financial devastation, what Scripture teaches about preparation, and how you can develop a comprehensive protection strategy that honors God while potentially providing peace of mind.

Scripture Spotlight

In Genesis 41, Joseph's preparation during seven years of plenty sustained Egypt through seven years of famine. His actions weren't driven by fear but by prudent response to God's warning, showing that preparation is an expression of faith.

The Illusion of Invincibility

Our culture often celebrates risk-taking while minimizing the importance of protection. We idolize entrepreneurs who "bet it all" but rarely hear stories about those who protected their families through wise planning. Social media showcases success stories of people who took massive risks and won, but rarely shows the far more numerous

cases of those who lost everything because they lacked adequate protection.

This cultural blind spot creates several common misconceptions:

"I'm young and healthy, so I don't need protection."
Youth and health are blessings, but they're not guarantees. According to the Social Security Administration, more than one in four of today's 20-year-olds will become disabled before retirement age. Life-altering accidents and illnesses don't check your age before striking.

"My employer benefits have me covered."
Many people assume their workplace benefits provide sufficient protection. However, employer-provided disability insurance typically covers only 60% of your income and often has significant limitations. According to the Forbes, the average long-term disability claim lasts 34.6 months. Could your family manage on 60% of your income for nearly three years?

"Insurance is just a way for companies to make money off my fear."
While the insurance industry certainly seeks to profit, this perspective misses the fundamental purpose of insurance: to transfer risk you cannot afford to bear. We readily insure our cars and homes but often neglect to protect our most valuable asset—our ability to earn an income.

"God will provide, so I don't need to worry about these things."
This spiritualized version of the invincibility myth misunderstands biblical provision. Yes, God provides, but often through the wisdom and foresight He gives us now. Trusting God doesn't mean ignoring the wisdom He offers in Scripture about preparation.

The truth is, developing a protection strategy isn't about fear or lack of faith. It's about wisdom, stewardship, and love for those who depend on you. It's about recognizing that while we trust God completely, we also use the mind and resources He's given us to fulfill our responsibilities to our families.

Biblical Wisdom on Preparation and Protection

Scripture provides clear guidance on the importance of preparing for uncertain futures. This wisdom isn't meant to contradict our trust in God but to express it through prudent action.

The Principle of Prudent Foresight

Proverbs 22:3 (which closely parallels our key verse) states: "*The prudent sees danger and hides himself, but the simple go on and suffer for it*." This verse appears twice in Proverbs, emphasizing its importance. The "prudent" person doesn't just recognize potential dangers but takes concrete action to protect themselves. This isn't driven by fear but by wisdom–the ability to foresee potential consequences and act accordingly.

Myth: "Having insurance shows a lack of faith in God's protection."

Truth: Biblical wisdom teaches preparation for foreseeable risks. Proverbs 27:12 states, "The prudent sees danger and hides himself," showing that precaution is wisdom, not faithlessness.

We see this principle exemplified in Joseph's administration of Egypt during the seven years of plenty. Genesis 41:47-49 tells us: "*During the seven plentiful years the earth produced abundantly, and he gathered up all the food of these seven years... and stored up food in the cities... Joseph stored up grain in great abundance, like the sand of the sea,*

until he ceased to measure it, for it could not be measured." Joseph's preparation wasn't a lack of faith in God's provision; it was his faithful response to the warning God had given.

Caring for Family as Spiritual Responsibility

In 1 Timothy 5:8, Paul doesn't mince words: "*But if anyone does not provide for his relatives, and especially for members of his household, he has denied the faith and is worse than an unbeliever*." While this passage is often applied to daily provision, its principle extends to protecting your family from foreseeable financial disasters.

This responsibility is highlighted in Psalm 112:5, which states: "*It is well with the man who deals generously and lends; who conducts his affairs with justice*." Part of conducting our affairs with justice includes ensuring that those who depend on us won't be left destitute if we're unable to provide.

Balancing Trust with Responsible Action

Proverbs 21:5 tells us, "*The plans of the diligent lead surely to abundance, but everyone who is hasty comes only to poverty*." Biblical wisdom consistently emphasizes that trust in God operates alongside—not in opposition to—diligent planning.

Jesus Himself illustrated this principle in Luke 14:28-30: "*For which of you, desiring to build a tower, does not first sit down and count the cost, whether he has enough to complete it? Otherwise, when he has laid a foundation and is not able to finish, all who see it begin to mock him, saying, 'This man began to build and was not able to finish*.'" Christ expected His followers to plan carefully, considering potential obstacles.

The biblical vision of preparation isn't rooted in anxiety but in faithful stewardship. It's not about trying to control every outcome but about responsibly managing the resources and knowledge God has given us. When we prepare wisely, we're not demonstrating a lack of faith; we're showing love for our families and respect for God's wisdom.

The High Cost of Inadequate Protection: Norma's Story*

Few stories have impacted me as deeply as Norma's. She came to me shortly after her husband James passed away suddenly at just 42 years old. James had been a dedicated Christian, a loving father to their two children, and a diligent provider for their family. By all accounts, he was a godly man who worked hard and loved his family well.

What made Norma's situation particularly heartbreaking wasn't just the unexpected loss of her husband. It was the preventable financial devastation that followed.

Like many Christians, James and Norma believed they had their bases covered when it came to life insurance. James had coverage through his employer, and they had never questioned whether it was adequate. They simply assumed the standard work policy was enough and never gave it a second thought.

That employer policy provided coverage equal to one year of James's salary. It seemed substantial enough when viewed as a lump sum. But the harsh reality? Between funeral expenses, outstanding medical bills,

and their ongoing monthly obligations, that money lasted Norma exactly eight months.

Instead of having the time and space to properly grieve her husband and comfort their children, Norma was forced to immediately begin job hunting. While still arranging her husband's funeral and figuring out how to parent their children alone, she also had to solve the impossible problem of replacing their primary income source.

Norma expressed that she felt abandoned twice—first by losing James, and then by the financial crisis that followed. She knew James would never have wanted this for their family. He genuinely thought he was doing the right thing to protect them.

What makes this situation particularly sobering is that it could have been prevented with relatively simple planning. For roughly the monthly cost of a few family dinners out, James could have secured enough term life insurance to:

1. Pay off their mortgage entirely
2. Cover their children's education
3. Replace his income for enough years to allow Norma to adjust and retrain if necessary
4. Provide a cushion for unexpected expenses

The words of 1 Timothy 5:8 resonate powerfully here: "But if anyone does not provide for his relatives, and especially for members of his household, he has denied the faith and is worse than an unbeliever." This biblical responsibility to provide doesn't end at death—in many ways, that's when proper provision becomes most critical.

Norma's story has a mixed ending. Through her church community and family support, she eventually stabilized her situation. She found employment, though at a significantly lower income than James had provided. The children's college funds were depleted for survival expenses. And the emotional toll of facing financial crisis amid profound grief left scars that are still healing.

Today, Norma has become one of the most passionate advocates I know for proper protection planning. She now shares her story with every couple she meets, determined to prevent others from experiencing the same painful financial crisis her family endured.

Her story illustrates a sobering truth: love isn't just expressed in daily provision but in preparing for possibilities we don't want to face. Protection planning isn't about fear or lack of faith—it's about fulfilling our God-given responsibility to care for those entrusted to us, even if we're no longer present to do so personally.

Finding Your Path to Biblical Protection

Norma's story illustrates a sobering truth: protection planning isn't a luxury or an optional financial exercise—it's a fundamental responsibility for those who care for others. What makes proper

protection planning challenging is that needs vary significantly based on your specific situation. A young family like James and Norma's has different requirements than empty nesters or single individuals. That's why personalized guidance is so valuable when creating your protection plan.

Practical Tip

Conduct a "protection audit" annually to identify your family's most significant financial vulnerabilities. Review insurance coverage, emergency funds, and legal documents to ensure they remain aligned with your current life stage and needs.

Proverbs 11:14 reminds us that "*in an abundance of counselors there is safety.*" This wisdom is particularly relevant when navigating the complex world of insurance and risk management. Many Christians rely on insurance agents who may excel at selling products but lack the comprehensive perspective needed to align protection strategies with biblical principles and overall financial goals.

As a CRPC® with pastoral experience, I help believers like Michael and Emma develop protection strategies that reflect both sound financial principles and biblical wisdom. Together, we address questions such as:

- What risks pose the greatest threat to your family's financial stability?
- How can you balance prudent protection with appropriate trust in God's provision?
- How do protection strategies change through different seasons of life?
- How can you ensure your protection plan aligns with your overall financial stewardship?

I believe that proper protection planning should bring peace, not anxiety. It should free you to live generously and purposefully, knowing

you've responsibly addressed major financial risks. If you're uncertain about the adequacy of your current protection strategy, I invite you to schedule a biblical wealth clarity call to evaluate your needs.

Building Your Biblical Protection Plan

Creating a comprehensive protection plan doesn't happen overnight, but it doesn't have to be overwhelming either. Here are four biblical approaches to help you take practical steps toward prudent preparation:

1. Assess and prioritize your risks.

Proverbs 27:23 instructs: "*Know well the condition of your flocks, and give attention to your herds.*" In modern terms, this means taking stock of your specific vulnerabilities.

Start by identifying your most significant risks based on your family situation, career, health history, and financial obligations. For most families, the priority risks include premature death of a provider, disability or critical illness, major medical expenses, and property loss.

Once you've identified these risks, evaluate which would have the most catastrophic financial impact if they occurred. This helps you allocate your protection budget where it matters most.

2. Build appropriate emergency reserves.

Proverbs 6:6-8 points to the ant as a model of preparation: "*Go to the ant, O sluggard; consider her ways, and be wise. Without having any chief, officer, or ruler, she prepares her bread in summer and gathers her food in harvest.*"

For most families, this means establishing an emergency fund with 3-6 months of essential expenses in a liquid, easily accessible account. If your income is variable or your job security is uncertain, consider aiming for the higher end of this range.

Remember, your emergency fund is not an investment—it's insurance. Its purpose isn't to grow wealth but to provide stability during unexpected financial storms. Keep it in a safe, liquid account like a high-yield savings account or money market fund.

3. Protect your family through proper insurance.
In Exodus 22:7, we read instructions about responsibility when someone's property is damaged: "*If a man gives to his neighbor money or goods to keep safe, and it is stolen from the man's house, then, if the thief is found, he shall pay double*." This passage illustrates the biblical principle of making someone whole after a loss—the fundamental concept behind insurance.

At minimum, most families should consider:

- **Term life insurance** sufficient to replace lost income and cover major obligations if a provider passes away.
- **Disability insurance** to replace income if you're unable to work due to illness or injury.
- **Health insurance** with appropriate deductibles and out-of-pocket maximums.
- **Property and casualty insurance** for your home and vehicles, with adequate liability coverage.

Insurance isn't about profiting from misfortune but about transferring risks you cannot afford to bear. Focus on protecting against catastrophic losses rather than minor inconveniences.

Insurance isn't about profiting from misfortune but about transferring risks you cannot afford to bear. Focus on protecting against catastrophic losses rather than minor inconveniences, recognizing that this approach reflects faithful stewardship, not a lack of trust in God. As you implement these protection strategies, do so with a heart that acknowledges God as your ultimate provider and protector, knowing that preparation honors Him by wisely managing the resources and wisdom He's provided.

Questions for Reflection

- What potential risks to your family's financial stability have you been avoiding thinking about?
- How might proper preparation actually free you to live more faithfully rather than fearfully?
- In what ways could your protection planning become a testimony of God's provision to others?

These questions aren't meant to create anxiety but to invite thoughtful consideration of your stewardship responsibilities. Many Christians find that addressing these issues brings peace rather than worry, knowing they've faithfully applied God's wisdom to protect those entrusted to their care.

Closing Prayer

"Father, I confess that fear and uncertainty have kept me paralyzed. In failing to plan for the unexpected, I have not lived up to the level of stewardship that You have called me to in my life. Give me the wisdom to see potential dangers and address them faithfully. Make my preparation an act of worship of You and an act of love toward my family and a testimony of Your provision and greatness to others. Amen."

9

Trust God Over Wealth

“As for the rich in this present age, charge them not to be haughty, nor to set their hopes on the uncertainty of riches, but on God who richly provides us with everything to enjoy.”
1 Timothy 6:17

What would it look like to truly trust God more than your bank account? It's a challenging question for Christians in a culture where financial security is often equated with success and stability. Even as believers, we can find ourselves clinching our fists around our resources instead of holding them with open hands before God.

The struggle isn't new. When Paul wrote to Timothy, he saw wealthy believers facing the same temptation we do today: finding security in their possessions rather than in their Provider. That's why he instructed them not to "*set their hopes on the uncertainty of riches, but on God who richly provides us with everything to enjoy.*" This isn't a command to reject wealth but to properly order our trust—God first, resources second.

In this chapter, we'll explore how trusting God over wealth transforms not just your financial decisions but your entire relationship with money. We'll see how Scripture guides us to enjoy God's provision

without idolizing it, and how this trust liberates us from financial anxiety to experience true peace and purpose.

The Illusion of Financial Self-Sufficiency

Our culture celebrates financial independence as the ultimate goal. "Financial freedom" podcasts, courses, and books proliferate with promises of security through accumulation. The underlying message is clear: with enough money, you can insulate yourself from life's uncertainties and eliminate the need to depend on anyone—even God.

Heart Check

Ask yourself: "What would cause me more distress—losing my savings or losing my connection with God?" Your honest answer reveals where your ultimate trust lies.

This mindset creeps into our thinking in subtle ways:

- Checking our bank accounts for peace of mind more often than we seek God in prayer.
- Making major decisions based primarily on financial implications rather than spiritual guidance.
- Feeling anxiety when markets fluctuate but complacency when our prayer life stagnates.
- Defining success by our financial growth rather than our spiritual growth.

Many practicing Christians report experiencing some level of financial anxiety despite believing that God is in control of their finances. This disconnect reveals how easily we can intellectually affirm God's provision while emotionally trusting our resources.

Jesus addressed this divided trust directly in Matthew 6:24 when He stated, "*No one can serve two masters, for either he will hate the one and love the other, or he will be devoted to the one and despise the other. You cannot serve God and money.*" The Greek word used for money here is "mammonas," (μαμωνᾶς) which represents more than just currency—it encompasses the entire system of wealth, possession, and financial security that competes for our ultimate trust.

The danger isn't in having resources but in how we relate to them. When wealth becomes our security blanket rather than a tool for serving God's purposes, we've fallen into a subtle but powerful form of idolatry. And like all idols, wealth makes promises it cannot keep. No amount of money can guarantee health, peace, purpose, or protection from life's most significant challenges.

The irony is that trusting wealth for security ultimately produces the opposite—anxiety. The more we accumulate, the more we fear losing it. Market volatility becomes emotionally devastating. Financial setbacks feel like existential threats. We become slaves to what we thought would give us freedom.

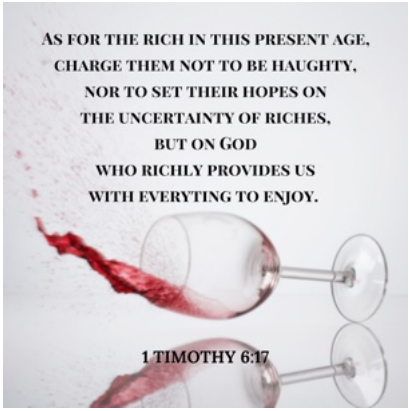
The biblical alternative isn't poverty or financial carelessness. It's properly ordered trust—recognizing God as the source of both our resources and our security, and handling wealth as grateful stewards rather than anxious owners.

Biblical Wisdom on Trusting God Over Wealth

Scripture doesn't condemn wealth itself but consistently warns against misplaced trust. From the Old Testament to the New, we

find a coherent message about the proper relationship between faith and finances.

The Danger of Misplaced Trust



In Psalm 49:6-7, we're warned about those who "*trust in their wealth and boast of the abundance of their riches*" because "*truly no man can ransom another, or give to God the price of his life.*" This Psalm points to wealth's ultimate limitation—it cannot solve our deepest problem (separation from God) or prevent our inevitable mortality.

Proverbs 11:28 states this principle directly: "*Whoever trusts in his riches will fall, but the righteous will flourish like a green leaf.*" The contrast is striking. Trusting in wealth leads to collapse, while righteousness (right relationship with God) leads to flourishing.

Jesus reinforced this warning with His parable of the rich fool in Luke 12:16-21. After a bountiful harvest, the man plans to build bigger barns to store his abundance, telling himself, "*Soul, you have ample goods laid up for many years; relax, eat, drink, be merry.*" But God calls him a "fool" because that very night his life would be demanded of him. Jesus concludes: "*So is the one who lays up treasure for himself and is not rich toward God.*"

The problem wasn't the man's wealth or even his saving—it was his self-centered security in his abundance and his failure to recognize God as the source and purpose of his provision.

God as the True Source of Security

Throughout Scriptures, God consistently presents Himself as our provider and protector. In Philippians 4:19, Paul confidently declares, "*And my God will supply every need of yours according to his riches in glory in Christ Jesus*." This promise doesn't guarantee wealth, but it does assure provision for genuine needs.

Hebrews 13:5-6 connects contentment directly to trust in God's presence: "*Keep your life free from love of money, and be content with what you have, for he has said, 'I will never leave you nor forsake you.' So we can confidently say, 'The Lord is my helper; I will not fear; what can man do to me?*'" Notice how the author grounds financial contentment not in having enough resources but in having God's unfailing presence.

In Matthew 6:25-33, Jesus addresses anxiety about material provision directly: "*Therefore I tell you, do not be anxious about your life, what you will eat or what you will drink, nor about your body, what you will put on... Look at the birds of the air... Consider the lilies of the field...*" He concludes with the life-changing instruction: "*But seek first the kingdom of God and his righteousness, and all these things will be added to you.*"

This teaching doesn't minimize the importance of work or wise financial management. Instead, it properly orders our priorities and places our ultimate trust in God rather than our own resourcefulness or accumulation.

The Right Use of Wealth

Paul's instruction in 1 Timothy 6:17-19 provides a balanced approach to wealth: "*As for the rich in this present age, charge them not to be haughty, nor to set their hopes on the uncertainty of riches, but on God who richly provides us with everything to enjoy. They are to do good, to be rich in*

good works, to be generous and ready to share, thus storing up treasure for themselves as a good foundation for the future, so that they may take hold of that which is truly life."

This passage offers several key insights:

1. God provides resources "to enjoy"—wealth isn't inherently evil.
2. Our hope should rest on God, not the "uncertainty of riches."
3. Wealth creates opportunity for good works and generosity.
4. True life isn't found in accumulation but in kingdom-focused stewardship.

Myth: "Financial security comes from having enough money."

Truth: True security comes only from God. As Hebrews 13:5-6 reminds us, "Keep your life free from love of money... for he has said, 'I will never leave you nor forsake you.' So we can confidently say, 'The Lord is my helper; I will not fear.'"

When we trust God over wealth, we're free to enjoy His provision without being enslaved by it. We can use resources strategically for eternal purposes rather than hoarding them for temporary security. And we can face financial uncertainty with confidence, knowing our ultimate Provider is faithful even when markets and economies are not.

From Worry to Witness: David and Sarah's Story*

I've known David and Sarah for years as devoted believers who faithfully served in our church community. Unlike many of my clients who struggle with wealth management, their challenge was making ends meet on a single income in our increasingly expensive city. David worked as a pilot at a smaller airline, while Sarah stayed home to raise their four young children - a decision they felt called to make despite the financial strain it created. David, always a capable theologian,

desired to go back to school and pursue a seminary degree so that he could better serve the church in preaching and teaching.

Month after month, they stretched every dollar, clipped coupons, budgeted meticulously, and still found themselves anxiously checking their bank balance before each bill came due. Despite being steadfast in their faith in other areas, financial worry had become a constant companion. David worked overtime whenever possible, feeling the weight of being their family's sole provider.

During a particularly difficult stretch, they confided that while they trusted God with their eternal salvation, somehow trusting Him with their monthly budget felt more challenging. They never missed their tithe, but beyond that faithful giving, fear often governed their financial decisions.

After a particularly stressful period when their water heater burst, causing a $4,000 repair bill and the transmission went out in his car (another $3,000 fix), David was as distraught as I've ever seen him. When I called him, David expressed his exhaustion from trying to be both provider and protector for their family, feeling inadequate in both roles.

This moment of vulnerability became their turning point. We spent time exploring what Scripture actually says about God's provision - not promises of wealth, but assurances of faithful care. Together, we worked through Matthew 6, where Jesus reminds us that the Father who clothes the lilies and feeds the birds is even more committed to meeting our needs.

Rather than creating a complex financial strategy, we developed a simple approach: faithful stewardship coupled with deliberate trust.

They continued their careful budgeting but committed to replacing worry with worship. Each time anxiety surfaced, they redirected it into prayer and thanksgiving for God's past provision.

The transformation in their hearts happened gradually, but what happened next was remarkable. Just three weeks after they made this spiritual shift, David learned that after months of negotiations, the pilots' union at his airline had finally secured approval for a new contract. This agreement included substantial across-the-board raises for all pilots, and in David's case, it meant an annual salary increase that moved him well into six figures.

When David called to share the news, he didn't focus on the money but instead expressed how the timing reminded him that God had seen their struggle all along.

What struck me most was how they responded to this unexpected blessing. Instead of upgrading their lifestyle, their first decision was to increase their giving. They dramatically increased their giving to their local church and show continuous hospitality by hosting small groups and bible studies in their home.

Sarah still stays home with their children, and they still budget carefully - old habits of good stewardship remain. But the anxiety that once plagued them has been replaced with a deep peace. Sarah later reflected that surrendering their financial future to God, not the money itself, was what transformed their lives. The raise simply confirmed God's trustworthiness.

Their story has become a powerful testimony in their church community. Not because God made them wealthy - that's not the point - but because they experienced firsthand what happens when we trust

God as our provider rather than seeing ourselves as the source of our security. David now eagerly works toward his seminary education and his goal of serving in the church full-time, knowing that God is the ultimate provider.

The Journey from Financial Anxiety to Faith-Based Security

David and Sarah's transformation didn't happen overnight, and it didn't happen without guidance. Like many believers, they needed someone who understood both financial principles and biblical wisdom to help them navigate the tension between practical stewardship and spiritual trust. Their journey from financial anxiety to confident faith required both scriptural foundation and practical application.

Proverbs 12:15 reminds us that "*The way of a fool is right in his own eyes, but a wise man listens to advice*." When it comes to ordering our trust properly—God first, resources second—most of us benefit from counsel that addresses both the practical and spiritual dimensions of money management.

Kingdom Principle

When your security rests in God rather than wealth, you're free to be generous, take career risks in service to His calling, and face financial uncertainties with peace instead of panic.

Unfortunately, most financial advisors focus exclusively on accumulation and protection strategies without addressing the heart issues that drive our financial decisions. They can help you build wealth but not necessarily in a way that nurtures trust in God. Meanwhile, well-meaning church leaders often offer spiritual encouragement about

trusting God without practical guidance on how this trust translates into financial decisions.

As a financial advisor with pastoral experience, I bridge this gap by helping clients like Emily and Mark develop wealth management strategies that strengthen rather than replace their trust in God. Together, we address questions such as:

- How can your financial plan reflect confidence in God's provision while exercising responsible stewardship?
- What practical steps can you take to reduce financial anxiety and increase faith-based security?
- How can your resources be strategically deployed to advance kingdom purposes while meeting your legitimate needs?
- What financial decisions would look different if you truly trusted God more than your wealth?

I believe financial peace comes not from having enough resources but from properly ordering your trust. If you find yourself caught between faith's call to trust God and finance's push toward self-sufficiency, I'd welcome the opportunity to help you develop an integrated approach that honors both biblical wisdom and financial prudence.

Schedule a no-strings-attached clarity call with me to explore how proper trust can transform your relationship with money and with God.

How to Trust God Over Wealth

Trusting God more than your resources doesn't happen automatically, especially in a culture that constantly reinforces financial self-reliance. Here are four biblical approaches to help you cultivate greater trust in God's provision:

1. Practice financial sabbaths.

In Exodus 20:8-11, God commands His people to observe a weekly sabbath—a day of rest and trust that acknowledges God as provider. This principle can be applied to our financial lives as well.

Consider implementing regular "financial sabbaths"—designated periods where you intentionally detach from financial activities and concerns. This might mean one day a week where you don't check investment accounts, make purchases, or even talk about money. Instead, use this time to reflect on God's faithfulness and provision in your life.

Many of my clients find that this practice gradually reduces their financial anxiety and reinforces their trust in God rather than their resources. A financial sabbath can be a weekly reminder that the world doesn't collapse when you're not managing everything—God remains in control.

2. Reframe financial decisions through prayer.

In Philippians 4:6-7, Paul instructs, "*Do not be anxious about anything, but in everything by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving let your requests be made known to God. And the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, will guard your hearts and your minds in Christ Jesus.*"

Before making significant financial decisions, commit to a period of prayer focused not primarily on outcomes but on alignment with God's

purposes. Ask questions like: "God, how would You have me use these resources?" "What would it look like to trust You more in this situation?" "How might this decision affect my dependence on You?"

This approach transforms financial decisions from merely practical considerations to spiritual exercises that nurture your relationship with God. The goal isn't to receive miraculous financial direction in every case, but to develop a habit of seeking God's wisdom above your own calculation.

3. Establish trust benchmarks.
In 1 Chronicles 29:14, David prays, "*But who am I, and what is my people, that we should be able thus to offer willingly? For all things come from you, and of your own have we given you*." This prayer acknowledges God as the ultimate source of all resources.

Create concrete "trust benchmarks" that practically acknowledge God's provision in your financial life. For example:

- Commit to giving the first 10% (or another percentage) of all income before addressing any other financial needs.
- When you receive unexpected income, designate a portion specifically for kingdom purposes.
- Keep a "provision journal" where you record specific instances of God meeting needs, creating a tangible record of His faithfulness.

These benchmarks aren't about earning God's favor but about creating regular reminders that He is your provider, worthy of your trust.

4. Right-size your financial safety nets.
In Matthew 6:19-21, Jesus teaches, "*Do not lay up for yourselves treasures on earth, where moth and rust destroy and where thieves break in and*

steal, but lay up for yourselves treasures in heaven… For where your treasure is, there your heart will be also.”

Examine your financial safety nets to ensure they reflect wise stewardship without becoming idolatrous security blankets. This isn't about abandoning prudent planning–it's about ensuring that your planning reflects trust in God.

Ask yourself: "Is my emergency fund appropriate for genuine needs, or has it become excessive due to fear?" "Am I saving for retirement responsibly or hoarding out of anxiety about the future?" "Could some portion of my 'just in case' resources be better used for kingdom purposes now?”

For many clients, right-sizing safety nets means maintaining responsible reserves while releasing the excess that serves only to soothe financial anxiety. This balance looks different for each person, but the underlying principle is universal: prudence reflects trust in God; fear-based excess reflects trust in wealth.

Remember that trusting God over wealth isn't a one-time decision but a lifelong practice. Each of these steps represents a concrete way to nurture that trust daily, moving gradually from anxiety to confidence in God's provision.

Questions for Reflection

- In what areas of your financial life do you find it most difficult to trust God fully?

- How might your spending, saving, or giving patterns change if you truly believed that God, not your resources, is your ultimate security?
- What specific financial worry could you surrender to God today as an act of trust?

These questions aren't meant to induce guilt but to invite honest examination of where your trust truly lies. For many believers, increased financial trust leads not to irresponsibility but to greater peace and generosity as they experience the freedom that comes from releasing wealth's grip on their hearts.

Closing Prayer

"Father, I confess that I've often found my security in my possessions. I acknowledge that my peace does not come from them, but solely from You. Thank You for being so generous toward me. Teach me what it means to enjoy Your gifts without worshiping them, and to live with open hands before You. Amen."

10

Seek Wise Counsel

"Without counsel plans fail, but with many advisers they succeed."
Proverbs 15:22

What financial decisions are you facing right now that keep you up at night? A career change? Retirement planning? Investment choices? Estate planning? Or perhaps just how to get your monthly budget under control? Whatever financial crossroads you're facing, God never intended for you to navigate it alone.

In a culture that celebrates self-reliance and DIY solutions, seeking advice can feel like admitting weakness. We have unlimited financial information at our fingertips—websites, books, podcasts, YouTube videos—all promising to guide us to financial success. With so many resources available, why would we need personal financial counsel?

Yet Scripture consistently affirms that wisdom comes through community and counsel. From the Old Testament to the New, we see God's people seeking and following wise advice, not as a sign of weakness but as an act of humility and prudence. Proverbs 15:22 states it plainly: "*Without counsel plans fail, but with many advisers they succeed*." This isn't just helpful advice—it's a biblical principle for

making sound decisions, especially with something as complex as your finances.

In this chapter, we'll explore why seeking wise financial counsel is biblical, what makes counsel truly "wise" from a Christian perspective, and how you can find advisors who will guide you with both professional expertise and biblical values.

The Danger of Financial Isolation

We live in the information age, where financial advice is more accessible than ever. Want to learn about retirement planning? There are thousands of articles online. Need help with budgeting? Dozens of apps promise to solve your problems. Curious about investing? Countless forums offer tips and strategies.

Yet despite this abundance of information, many Christians find themselves making costly financial mistakes. According to Nerdwallet in 2024, 69% of Americans admit to having made significant financial decisions they later regretted during that year. What's perhaps more concerning is how few Christians actively integrate biblical wisdom into their financial decisions. In my years of financial ministry, I've observed that while most believers affirm that Scripture offers wisdom about money, only a small fraction consistently seek biblical counsel when facing financial crossroads.

Why this disconnect? Three key factors create what I call "financial isolation":

1. Information Overload Without Discernment

The sheer volume of financial advice can be paralyzing. Much of it is contradictory, and without a framework for discernment, Christians struggle to determine which advice aligns with biblical principles. Should you prioritize aggressive wealth building or generous giving? Focus on eliminating all debt or leverage "good debt" for investment? Different voices offer different answers, often without biblical context.

2. One-Size-Fits-All Solutions

Generic financial advice rarely addresses your specific situation, calling, and season of life. A 25-year-old single professional, a 40-year-old parent saving for college, and a 65-year-old approaching retirement all face different financial challenges requiring personalized wisdom. Books and articles can offer principles, but they can't account for your unique circumstances and God-given calling.

3. Separation of Financial and Spiritual Guidance

Perhaps most critically, many Christians compartmentalize their finances and faith. They might seek spiritual guidance from pastors and financial guidance from advisors, but rarely find counsel that integrates both perspectives. This division creates a practical dualism where financial decisions are made primarily on technical grounds rather than as an expression of faith and stewardship.

The result? Christians make financial decisions in isolation, missing the wisdom that comes through community and counsel. This isolation

often leads to choices that seem financially sound but may not align with God's purposes for their resources or their unique calling in His kingdom.

The solution isn't more information—it's biblical discernment applied to your specific situation through wise, faith-aligned counsel. As Proverbs 12:15 reminds us, "*The way of a fool is right in his own eyes, but a wise man listens to advice.*" Seeking counsel isn't a sign of ignorance; it's a mark of biblical wisdom.

Biblical Wisdom on Seeking Counsel

Scripture provides abundant guidance on the importance of seeking and following wise counsel, particularly for major decisions. This isn't a minor theme but a consistent principle throughout God's Word.

The Biblical Pattern of Multiple Counselors

Proverbs repeatedly emphasizes the value of multiple advisors: "*Without counsel plans fail, but with many advisers they succeed*" (Proverbs 15:22).

"*Where there is no guidance, a people falls, but in an abundance of counselors there is safety*" (Proverbs 11:14).

"*Plans are established by counsel; by wise guidance wage war*" (Proverbs 20:18).

The wisdom literature doesn't just suggest counsel as helpful—it presents it as essential for success and safety. Notice the consequences

described: without counsel, plans fail and people fall. This isn't merely about making good choices; it's about avoiding disaster.

The Dangers of Rejecting Wise Counsel

One of Scripture's most sobering examples of rejected counsel appears in 1 Kings 12. When Rehoboam became king, he faced a crucial decision about how to govern Israel. The experienced elders advised him to lighten the people's burden and speak kindly to them. Instead, Rehoboam followed the brash advice of his young friends to increase demands on the people.

Warning Sign

If you're making major financial decisions without input from others, you may be missing blind spots that could derail your stewardship. Even David, a "man after God's own heart," needed Nathan's perspective.

The result? The kingdom split, with ten tribes rejecting Rehoboam's leadership. This catastrophic outcome—the division of God's people—stemmed directly from rejecting wise counsel in favor of advice that appealed to his pride.

This account isn't just ancient history; it's a warning to us. When we reject balanced, experienced counsel in favor of advice that aligns with our existing biases or desires, we risk comparable disasters in our own sphere of responsibility.

Jesus' Model of Community

While Jesus is the ultimate source of wisdom, it's noteworthy that He still operated in community. He selected twelve disciples with whom He shared life and ministry. He sent them out in pairs rather than alone (Luke 10:1). Even at His most vulnerable moment in Gethsemane, He brought Peter, James, and John with Him to pray (Matthew 26:36-38).

The early church continued this pattern. The apostles made decisions together (Acts 15:6-29). Paul traveled with companions like Barnabas, Silas, and Timothy. The New Testament epistles emphasize mutual submission and the interdependence of believers.

This consistent biblical pattern reveals God's design: we weren't created to make decisions in isolation, but in community with wise counsel. This principle applies particularly to financial decisions, which often have far-reaching implications for our families, ministries, and Kingdom impact.

Balancing Independence and Counsel

To be clear, biblical counsel doesn't mean abdication of responsibility. Scripture calls us to be discerning about the advice we receive: "*The simple believes everything, but the prudent gives thought to his steps*" (Proverbs 14:15). We are ultimately responsible for our decisions, even when influenced by others' advice.

The biblical approach to counsel isn't blind following but prayerful discernment. We seek multiple perspectives, evaluate them against Scripture, pray for wisdom, and ultimately make decisions we believe honor God. The goal isn't to outsource our choices but to enrich them with godly wisdom beyond our own limited perspective.

From Financial Fragmentation to Kingdom Purpose: Robert and Linda's Story*

When Robert and Linda first sat down across from me, they brought a thick folder stuffed with statements, policies, and account documents.

This couple in their mid-sixties had accumulated a lifetime of financial products that had become overwhelming to manage.

Heart Check

Ask yourself: "What keeps me from seeking financial counsel –pride, fear of judgment, cost concerns, or past disappointments?" Identifying these barriers is the first step toward overcoming them.

As they spread the papers across my desk, it became clear they had lost track of exactly what they owned and why they owned it. Robert, a retired civil servant who had transitioned to business ownership, and Linda, a nurse who had worked at several different hospitals throughout her career, had followed financial advice from various sources throughout their lives, resulting in a fragmented financial picture.

Their financial situation reflected their diverse career paths and decades of well-intentioned decisions. They had multiple IRAs, Roth accounts, 401(k)s, 403(b)s, and a Thrift Savings Plan from Robert's government service. They owned three rental properties, had purchased several annuities, maintained multiple life insurance policies, and held various investment accounts across seven different financial institutions.

As we discussed their situation, they expressed frustration that each financial professional they'd met over the years had sold them something different. Each product had seemed appropriate at the time, but viewing everything together revealed a financial jigsaw puzzle with pieces from different boxes.

Their situation is remarkably common, especially among clients approaching retirement. After decades of working with different advisors–each addressing a specific need without seeing the whole picture–they end up with a collection of products rather than a

coherent strategy. These products may have been appropriate when purchased, but without integration, they create unnecessary complexity, potential tax inefficiencies, and misalignment with core values.

We began our work together with a comprehensive inventory. Each account, policy, and property was documented with its current value, purpose, cost, and tax treatment. Then we had deeper conversations about their faith journey and what mattered most to them in this season of life.

What became clear was that while Robert and Linda had significant resources, their financial structure wasn't aligned with their stated priorities. They expressed a desire to support their church's building campaign and their grandson's Christian education, yet their assets were positioned in ways that limited their giving capacity. They wanted financial simplicity in retirement but were spending hours each month managing scattered accounts. They hoped to leave a legacy for their children and grandchildren but had outdated estate documents that would create unnecessary complications.

Over the next several months, we developed and implemented a streamlined plan that brought clarity and purpose to their finances:

- We consolidated their retirement accounts to reduce complexity and fees.
- We evaluated their rental properties and sold the one requiring the most management time.
- We replaced several outdated insurance policies with more appropriate coverage.
- We repositioned assets to improve tax efficiency and increase their giving capacity.

- We updated their estate documents to reflect their current wishes and values.

The transformation for Robert and Linda wasn't just administrative—it was deeply meaningful. During our review meetings, they expressed a profound shift in perspective. They no longer viewed their finances as merely accumulated wealth but as resources to be stewarded for kingdom purposes.

I observed a visible sense of relief in both of them as our plan took shape. Robert, typically more reserved with his emotions, began to engage more actively in conversations about legacy and generosity. They both felt much more comfortable knowing their financial house was in order and aligned with their faith values.

What made the difference wasn't just organizing their accounts—though that was necessary. The real breakthrough came through integrating their faith values with their financial resources. When they saw how their reorganized finances could better support the Kingdom purposes they cared about, every decision became clearer.

Two years later, Robert and Linda have become enthusiastic advocates for comprehensive financial planning. They've experienced firsthand the difference between having financial products and having a purpose-driven financial plan. Their story reflects Solomon's wisdom in Ecclesiastes 4:9-10: "*Two are better than one, because they have a good reward for their toil. For if they fall, one will lift up his fellow.*"

With the right counsel, they no longer faced their complex financial decisions alone—and the result was a simplified structure that freed them to focus on what matters most.

Finding Your Financial Guide

Robert and Linda's transformation highlights something I've observed repeatedly: information alone rarely creates lasting financial change. Most Christians don't lack financial data—they lack integrated wisdom applied to their specific situation. That's why finding the right financial guide can be transformative for your stewardship journey.

As Proverbs 13:20 reminds us, "*Whoever walks with the wise becomes wise, but the companion of fools will suffer harm.*" The financial advisors you choose to "walk with" will significantly influence your financial decisions and, by extension, your ability to fulfill God's calling on your life.

Myth: "Seeking financial advice means I lack faith or understanding."

Truth: Scripture consistently affirms the value of wise counsel. Proverbs 15:22 states plainly: "Without counsel plans fail, but with many advisers they succeed." Seeking guidance is biblical wisdom, not weakness.

But how do you find advisors who offer truly wise counsel—guidance that integrates professional expertise with biblical values? Most financial professionals are trained in product knowledge and technical strategies but lack understanding of biblical stewardship principles. Meanwhile, many church leaders offer biblical teaching about money but lack the technical expertise to guide complex financial decisions.

As both a CRPC® and former pastor, I've observed this gap from both sides. Technical knowledge without biblical wisdom leads to financially efficient but spiritually empty decisions. Biblical teaching without practical application remains theoretical rather than transformative.

This integration of financial expertise and biblical wisdom guides my approach with clients. Together, we address questions like:

- How can your financial plan reflect your God-given calling and priorities?
- What financial strategies will help you be maximally generous while still meeting your family's needs?
- How can your investments align with biblical values without sacrificing appropriate returns?
- What legacy planning approaches will transfer both your resources and your values to future generations?

I believe finances aren't just about numbers—they're about discipleship. Each financial decision is an opportunity to grow in faith and stewardship.

My hope is that the questions I've provided will serve you well in finding the right counsel, even if that isn't me. The goal isn't to direct you to a specific advisor but to equip you with biblical discernment in selecting someone who will honor both your financial goals and your faith values. If you're navigating complex financial questions or simply wanting to ensure your finances align with biblical principles, I invite you to schedule a no-obligation clarity call to explore how faith-integrated financial counsel might serve your journey.

Ten Essential Questions for Evaluating Financial Counsel

Finding truly wise financial counsel requires discernment. I want to help you identify the right financial advisor who aligns with your values, even if it isn't me. Here are ten essential questions to ask during your search, each grounded in biblical wisdom:

1. How do you get paid?

Proverbs 28:20 tells us, "*A faithful man will abound with blessings, but whoever hastens to be rich will not go unpunished*." Understanding an advisor's compensation model reveals potential conflicts of interest.

Ask whether they receive commissions on products they recommend, charge a percentage of assets under management, or use a fee-only model. Each approach has legitimate applications, but transparency about compensation is essential for trust. An advisor who hesitates to clearly explain their fee structure may not be the right fit.

2. Are you a fiduciary?

Philippians 2:3-4 instructs us to "*do nothing from selfish ambition or conceit, but in humility count others more significant than yourselves. Let each of you look not only to his own interests, but also to the interests of others.*" This principle of putting others' interests first should guide financial advisors.

Understanding an advisor's fiduciary obligations and how they're compensated helps you assess potential conflicts of interest. Many advisors operate as fiduciaries in certain aspects of their practice, meaning they're legally obligated to put your interests first. Others may operate under a "suitability" standard, which requires

recommendations to be appropriate but not necessarily optimal for your situation.

It's worth noting that different compensation models serve different needs. Fee-based advisors charge for their advice and planning services, which can provide objectivity but might not be necessary for simpler aspects of your financial life, like emergency savings accounts. Commission-based advisors may offer valuable products without charging planning fees, which can be appropriate in certain circumstances.

Ask about when and how they act as a fiduciary and how their compensation aligns with different services they provide. The key is transparency—a trustworthy advisor will clearly explain their ethical obligations and how they're compensated for various services.

3. How do you incorporate faith-based principles into financial planning?

In Psalm 24:1, we're reminded that "*The earth is the LORD's and the fullness thereof.*" Wise financial counsel begins with recognizing God's ultimate ownership of all resources.

Listen carefully to how potential advisors address this question. Do they naturally incorporate stewardship language, or does their response feel rehearsed? Ask for specific examples of how biblical principles have shaped their recommendations. Their perspective on ownership and stewardship will fundamentally influence the advice they offer.

4. What is your investment philosophy?

Proverbs 21:5 says, "*The plans of the diligent lead surely to abundance, but everyone who is hasty comes only to poverty.*" An advisor's investment

approach should reflect thoughtful, principle-based reasoning rather than chasing trends or making emotional decisions.

Ask about their approach to risk, market timing, diversification, and asset allocation. Be wary of advisors who promise unrealistic returns or claim to consistently "beat the market." A solid investment philosophy should be explainable in straightforward terms and remain consistent across market conditions.

5. Who is your typical client?
Proverbs 27:23 advises, "*Know well the condition of your flocks, and give attention to your herds.*" Applied to financial counsel, this means advisors should have relevant experience with situations like yours.

You'll be best served by an advisor who regularly works with people in similar circumstances and understands your specific needs. If you're a business owner, retiree, medical professional, or ministry worker, ask about their experience with clients in your situation. The right advisor should demonstrate familiarity with your unique challenges and opportunities.

6. What are your credentials?
Exodus 35:30-35 describes how God specifically called and equipped certain individuals with skills for their work. While all believers are called to stewardship, not all are equally equipped to provide financial counsel.

Verify credentials, education, and specialized training. Common designations include CFP® (Certified Financial Planner), CFA (Chartered Financial Analyst), CRPC® (Chartered Retirement Planning Counselor), and ChFC (Chartered Financial Consultant). While

credentials don't guarantee wisdom, they do indicate a commitment to professional standards and ongoing education.

7. How would we work together and communicate?
First Thessalonians 5:11 encourages us to "*encourage one another and build one another up*." Your relationship with your financial advisor should foster mutual understanding and growth.

Ask about the frequency of meetings, availability between scheduled appointments, and their communication style. Will you work primarily with the advisor or with a team? What regular reports will you receive? The answers should align with your preferences for engagement and communication.

8. What services do you provide?
Second Timothy 3:16-17 tells us that Scripture equips us "*for every good work*." Similarly, your advisor should be equipped to address your comprehensive financial needs.

Some advisors focus narrowly on investments, while others provide comprehensive planning covering retirement, tax strategies, estate planning, insurance, and more. Clarify whether they handle specific needs important to you, such as charitable giving strategies, business succession planning, or legacy planning with biblical values.

9. What's important to you?
Matthew 6:21 reminds us that "*where your treasure is, there your heart will be also*." An advisor's personal values will inevitably influence their professional guidance.

Listen carefully to what motivates them in their work. Do they focus solely on financial outcomes, or do they speak about the impact of their

work on clients' lives and spiritual well-being? Their answer will reveal whether they view financial planning as merely a technical exercise or as meaningful stewardship.

10. What questions do you have for me?
Proverbs 18:13 cautions, "*If one gives an answer before he hears, it is his folly and shame.*" A wise advisor should demonstrate curiosity about your situation before offering recommendations.

Pay attention to what questions they ask you. Do they inquire about your values, goals, and concerns? Are they interested in your family dynamics and charitable interests? The quality of their questions often reveals more about their approach than their answers to your questions.

Remember, no financial advisor perfectly embodies all these qualities. The goal isn't finding perfection but identifying counsel that will help you grow as a faithful steward of God's resources. As you interview potential advisors, pray for discernment and trust that God will guide you to the counsel you need.

Questions for Reflection

- In what financial areas have you been trying to make decisions without seeking adequate counsel?
- What barriers (pride, cost concerns, bad experiences) have kept you from seeking wise financial advice?
- How might your financial decisions be different if they were consistently informed by both biblical wisdom and professional expertise?

If these questions reveal areas where additional counsel would benefit your stewardship journey, consider scheduling a clarity call to explore next steps. Remember, seeking counsel isn't a sign of weakness but of biblical wisdom.

Closing Prayer

"Father, I confess my tendency toward self-reliance in financial matters. Thank You for providing biblical wisdom and qualified counsel to guide my stewardship. Give me discernment to recognize truly wise advisors and humility to heed godly counsel. May all my financial decisions honor You as the true owner of everything. Amen."

11

Tying it all Together

The end of the matter; all has been heard. Fear God and keep his commandments, for this is the whole duty of man.
Ecclesiastes 12:13

What would your financial life look like if every decision you made was in perfect alignment with God's design? It's a question that might seem idealistic, but it points us toward an essential truth: our financial lives are meant to be lived in harmony with our Creator's wisdom.

Throughout this book, we've explored ten biblical principles for financial stewardship. Each stands powerful on its own, but together, they form a comprehensive framework for honoring God with every aspect of your finances. These aren't merely strategies for building wealth—though they often lead to material blessing. They're pathways to aligning your financial life with God's kingdom purposes.

The writer of Ecclesiastes, after exploring every avenue of human experience, came to a profound conclusion: "*The end of the matter; all has been heard. Fear God and keep his commandments, for this is the whole duty of man.*" This wisdom applies powerfully to our finances. After all the strategies, techniques, and advice, the heart of biblical

financial stewardship comes down to this: reverent awe of God that leads to faithful obedience.

In this final chapter, we'll bring together what we've learned, examine how these principles work in concert, and chart a path forward for implementing biblical financial wisdom in your life.

The Integrated Life of Biblical Stewardship

Throughout this book, we've separated financial principles for the sake of clarity, but in practice, they function as an integrated whole. Consider how these principles work together:

When you acknowledge **God's ownership of everything** (Chapter 1), you naturally approach financial decisions with greater reverence and care. This foundational truth guides every aspect of stewardship.

This recognition leads you to **live within your means** (Chapter 2), avoiding the bondage of debt and creating margin for God's purposes in your finances.

With this foundation of financial freedom, you're positioned to **save for the future** (Chapter 3), preparing wisely for needs and opportunities God may bring your way.

As you build financial stability, you guard your heart against materialism by **avoiding greed and pursuing contentment** (Chapter 4), finding joy in God's provision rather than endless acquisition.

This contentment frees you to **give generously** (Chapter 5), investing in God's kingdom and experiencing the joy that comes through biblical liberality.

Your approach to work changes as you **pursue diligence** (Chapter 6), viewing your labor as worship and creating value for others through excellence.

With this integrated approach to current finances, you begin to think beyond yourself, **planning your legacy** (Chapter 7) to bless future generations with both resources and values.

Because you recognize life's uncertainties, you **prepare for the unexpected** (Chapter 8), protecting your family from foreseeable risks without succumbing to fear.

Through it all, you **trust God over wealth** (Chapter 9), finding security in your relationship with Him rather than in accumulated resources.

And you don't walk this journey alone, but **seek wise counsel** (Chapter 10) from advisors who share your biblical values and can help you apply God's wisdom to your specific situation.

These principles don't operate in isolation. They form a tapestry of faithful stewardship, each strengthening the others. When one area weakens, it affects the entire framework. For example, if you fail to live within your means, your ability to save, give, and leave a legacy all

suffer. If you succumb to greed, your generosity diminishes. If you neglect wise counsel, you may miss blind spots in your stewardship.

Conversely, growth in one area often strengthens others. As you give more generously, contentment typically increases. As you plan your legacy thoughtfully, your daily financial decisions become more purposeful. As you acknowledge God's ownership more fully, trust in His provision deepens.

The Transformation of Financial Discipleship

Over my years as both a pastor and financial advisor, I've observed a consistent pattern in those who embrace biblical financial principles. The journey typically unfolds in three stages:

Stage 1: Relief

Most people initially seek financial guidance because of immediate pressures—debt, inadequate savings, retirement concerns, or specific financial goals. The first stage of transformation brings relief from these pressures through practical application of biblical principles.

I think of my clients Mark and Jennifer*, who came to me buried under $78,000 of consumer debt and feeling hopeless about their financial future. By embracing the principles of God's ownership and living within their means, they experienced the tremendous relief of becoming debt-free within three years. This initial relief was powerful, but it was only the beginning of their journey.

Stage 2: Stability
As financial pressures ease, believers enter a season of building stability—establishing emergency funds, implementing consistent giving, developing long-term savings habits, and creating protection strategies. This stage can bring a profound sense of peace and confidence.

For Mark and Jennifer, stability came as they built their emergency fund, increased their tithing, and established college savings for their children. The constant financial stress that had once characterized their marriage was replaced by calm discussions about stewardship. Their financial stability didn't just affect their bank accounts—it transformed their relationship.

Stage 3: Purpose
The most beautiful transformation occurs when financial decisions become primarily about purpose rather than pressure or even stability. In this stage, believers ask deeper questions: "How can my resources advance God's kingdom?" "What unique calling has God given our family?" "How can our financial decisions leave a Christ-honoring legacy?"

Mark and Jennifer entered this stage when they began discussing how to use their newfound financial margin to support evangelistic work they felt passionate about. They adjusted their retirement timeline to allow for short-term mission trips. They reworked their estate plan to include significant legacy gifts to ministries. Their financial decisions became less about their security and more about kingdom impact.

This progression—from relief to stability to purpose—reflects the maturing process of financial discipleship. While the practical benefits of biblical stewardship are significant (becoming debt-free, building savings, preparing for retirement), the heart transformation is even

more profound. Financial decisions become acts of worship, expressions of values, and investments in eternity.

Your Next Steps

As we conclude this journey together, you might be wondering, "Where do I start?" With ten principles and countless applications, the path forward might seem overwhelming. Let me suggest a simple, sequential approach to implementing biblical financial wisdom:

1. Begin with acknowledgment.
Start by personally acknowledging God's ownership of everything you have. Pray the stewardship prayer from Chapter 1: "Lord, these resources are Yours. Show me how to use them for Your glory." This spiritual foundation precedes all practical steps.

2. Get a clear picture.
You can't steward what you don't understand. Take inventory of your current financial situation—income, expenses, debts, savings, and investments. Many of my clients are surprised by what they discover in this process, finding both challenges and opportunities they hadn't recognized.

3. Address immediate financial dangers.
If you're facing significant debt, inadequate emergency savings, or insufficient insurance protection, address these immediate concerns first. These issues represent financial vulnerabilities that can undermine your broader stewardship goals.

4. Establish core stewardship habits.
Implement the fundamental practices of biblical financial management: consistent giving, purposeful saving, thoughtful spending, and diligent work. These habits form the daily and monthly rhythms of faithful stewardship.

5. Develop longer-term strategies.
Once immediate concerns are addressed and core habits established, focus on longer-term aspects of stewardship—retirement planning, college funding, estate planning, and legacy giving. These elements require more complex planning but rest on the foundation of the previous steps.

6. Seek accountability and adjustments.
Financial stewardship isn't a "set it and forget it" endeavor. Regular review with trusted counsel helps you stay aligned with biblical principles and adjust your approach as life circumstances change. This ongoing process keeps stewardship from becoming stagnant.

This sequential approach doesn't mean you ignore later steps until earlier ones are perfected. Rather, it provides a framework for prioritizing your efforts and preventing overwhelm. Financial transformation is a journey, not an overnight change. Each faithful step builds upon previous ones, creating momentum toward comprehensive biblical stewardship.

The Heart of Stewardship

As we close this exploration of biblical financial principles, I want to return to where we began—with the recognition that money is ultimately a heart issue. Jesus taught that "*where your treasure is, there*

your heart will be also" (Matthew 6:21). Your financial decisions both reflect and shape your spiritual life.

The goal of biblical stewardship isn't merely financial success—it's spiritual transformation. When you align your finances with God's principles, you position yourself to experience:

- Freedom from the anxiety of financial uncertainty.
- Purpose in your daily work and financial decisions.
- Generosity that reflects God's character and brings joy.
- Legacy that extends your values beyond your lifetime.
- Peace that comes from knowing you're honoring God with His resources.

These outcomes emerge not from perfect financial strategies but from a heart that increasingly recognizes God's ownership and seeks His purposes. The technical aspects of financial management matter, but they serve the deeper purpose of faithful stewardship.

I'm reminded of the commendation given to the faithful servants in Jesus' parable: "*Well done, good and faithful servant. You have been faithful over a little; I will set you over much. Enter into the joy of your master*" (Matthew 25:21). This is the ultimate aim of biblical financial stewardship—to hear those words from our Master.

An Invitation to Continued Growth

The principles we've explored are timeless, but their application in your specific situation is unique. Your financial journey will have its own challenges, opportunities, and calling. That's why personalized guidance can be so valuable in applying biblical wisdom to your particular circumstances.

If you've resonated with the principles in this book and desire help implementing them in your life, I invite you to schedule a no-obligation clarity call. During this conversation, we can:

- Discuss your current financial situation and concerns.
- Identify which biblical principles need particular attention in your life.
- Explore how faith-integrated financial planning might serve your journey.
- Determine whether ongoing guidance would benefit your stewardship.

Whether or not we work together formally, my prayer is that this book has equipped and encouraged you to steward your finances in a way that honors God and advances His purposes. May your financial life increasingly reflect the wisdom, generosity, and faithfulness of your Creator.

The Conclusion of the Matter

Until now, I have ended each chapter with a prayer for you to pray, asking the Lord to help you in your financial journey. But to end this book, I want to thank you and conclude like we do in Church every week: by praying a blessing over *you*.

So thank you, dear reader, for the privilege of your time and attention. Thank you for taking the Word of God so seriously that you seek to obey it with your money. And thank you for inspiring me to be a better financial advisor and, more importantly, a better follower of Christ.

"And let the peace of Christ rule in your hearts, to which indeed you were called in one body. And be thankful. Let the word of Christ dwell in you

richly, teaching and admonishing one another in all wisdom, singing psalms and hymns and spiritual songs, with thankfulness in your hearts to God. And whatever you do, in word or deed, do everything in the name of the Lord Jesus, giving thanks to God the Father through him."
Colossians 3:15-17

To the King and His kingdom, now and forevermore. Amen.

-Andrew Zoll

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